

INBRIEF



Office-bearers of Tamil Film Producers' Council meet Vijay

The Tamil Film Producers' Council office-bearers, led by its president G.K.M. Tamil Kumaran, secretary S. Kathiresan, vice-presidents S. Kamalakannan and R.K. Suresh, treasurer N. Subash Chandrabose, and joint secretary Sujatha Vijaykumar, met Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay at the Secretariat on Monday.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (May 19, Tuesday), the following articles are available:

- The warning signs in India's import bill newsth.live/indianimportbill
- India still short on expertise, tools to manage fungal health burden newsth.live/fungaldisease

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Timings CHENNAI

TUESDAY, MAY. 19

RISE 05:43 SET 18:28

RISE 07:56 SET 21:26

WEDNESDAY, MAY. 20

RISE 05:43 SET 18:29

RISE 09:04 SET 22:25

THURSDAY, MAY. 21

RISE 05:43 SET 18:29

RISE 10:08 SET 23:18

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	37	28
Chennai Airport	38	28
Chennai City	35	28

Chennai Airport Today
36°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm. Night also will be comfortable. Dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
37°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU

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S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER

e-Tender Notice No. : 4634-GRC-CE-C-II-17-2026. For & on behalf of President of India, Chief Engineer (CON)/II/Garden Reach, Kolkata-700043 invites e-tender for the following work : Following tender has been uploaded on website www.ireps.gov.in The tender will be closed at 12.00 hrs. on due date. **Brief Description of Works :** Composite work for Execution of work for Yard remodeling works at Adra-Sanka-Rukni in connection with Adra-Sanka-Rukni doubling Project under the jurisdiction of Dy CE/Con/Adra. **Approx. Cost :** ₹ 82.19 Crore. **Bid Security :** ₹ 1,64,38,300/- **Completion Period :** 24 months. **Closing Date :** 12.06.2026. Interested tenderers may visit website www.ireps.gov.in for full details/ description/ specification of the tender and submit their bids online. In no case manual tenders for these items will be accepted. **NB :** "Prospective Bidders may regularly visit www.ireps.gov.in to participate in all other tenders." (PR-183)

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

E-OPEN TENDER NOTICE NO. S&T/SEE/E-OT/26-27/06, Date: 13.05.2026

The DRG (Sig. & Telecom)/SEE for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-Tenders for the following works. The last date of online E-tendering is 08.06.2026 up to 12:00 hrs. All information and tender documents related to E-tender is available on website – www.ireps.gov.in.

E-Tender No. : S&T/SEE/E-OT/26-27/06, Name of Work : Strengthening of signalling arrangements/infrastructures for dual detection using MSDAC in parallel to DC track circuit at BAGL & STLR. Approx Cost (In Rs.) : ₹3,70,60,857.73, Earnest Money (In Rs.): ₹7,41,300/-, Cost of Tender Document (In Rs.) (Non-refundable) : ₹0.00, Completion period : 09 (Nine) Month from date of issue of LOA

The above tender notice is available on website www.ireps.gov.in. Uploading date 13.05.2026. RIGHT OF RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER: Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone /modify or to cancel any one or all the tenders without assigning any reasons.

Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer/ ECR/Sonpur PR/0246/SEE/S&T/T/26-27/36

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras

Today: At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall from 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. – Compositions of Purandara-dasa – Dr. V. Subashri (Vocal), Mantha Srirama (Violin), Kaushik Sridhar (Mridangam) – Programme under the endowment instituted by Sri. P. Seshadri, Managing Trustee, Thyagaraja Music Festival Trust.

Shri Ariyakudi Music Foundation, Hamsadhwani and SciArt, USA

Ct: 9176011647

Cordially invite for the celebration of 136th birth anniversary of SHRI ARIYAKUDI at RAGA-SUDHA Hall. Today 5.45 pm: Carnatic Vocal Concert: Vocal - AISHWARYA VIDYA RAGHUNATH. Violin - Madan Mohan. Mrudangam - Arun Prakash. Kanjeera - Anirudh Athreya. 7.30 pm: Tributes to Shri Ariyakudi - Chief Guest Shri KT Raghavan. 7.45 pm: Bharathanatyam - Dr. S. R. Meenakshi Priya Raghavan.

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Government of India certificate will be awarded

AAI starts construction of 10 rapid exit taxiways at airport

The project was planned anticipating a rise in aircraft and passenger traffic after the opening of T3 International Terminal. The work will be completed in a year at an estimated cost of ₹230 cr.

PORT CALL

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

As work on the city side of the Chennai airport is under way with the construction of the T3 International Terminal, a major airside work commenced recently to expand the number of aircraft movement and help airlines save fuel.

The Airports Authority of India (AAI) has begun the work to build 10 rapid exit taxiways at the airport. The project will aid aircraft in vacating the runway quickly and, in turn, allow them to cut down on fuel consumption. It will also help manage airside congestion in the future.

AAI officials said they had applied for clearance from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), and after the approval came in the last



Efficiency boost: The project will aid aircraft in vacating the runway quickly and save fuel and also help in managing airside congestion. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

week of April, the work commenced.

"After a few years of construction, we finished building a couple of rapid exit taxiways. Now, additional ones are also planned to enhance the efficiency of the airport. Currently, the airport handles 36 aircraft movements an hour and such infrastructure will facilitate the airport to handle 45 movements an hour in the future, when air traffic in-

creases. The runway occupancy time (RoT), the period of time an aircraft is on the runway, for the main runway will decrease from 70 seconds to 60 seconds," an official said. At present, the airport has aircraft movement of nearly 450-460 planes per day.

"When the Phase II Modernisation Project is completed with the opening of the T3 International Terminal in December, the air and passenger traffic will

slowly increase. To handle these, we have planned this project," another official said.

The planning for this work began as early as 2024 and had to go through various levels of approvals. The project will be completed in a year. Initially, 11 rapid exit taxiways were planned, but the AAI changed it to 10 in the final plan. The revised estimated cost now stands at ₹230 crore, officials added.

Man found dead at building site in Maduravoyal, two detained

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police have detained two persons in connection with a case in which a 24-year-old worker was found dead under suspicious circumstances at a building site in Maduravoyal on Sunday.

The deceased was identified as Silambarasan of Villupuram. He had been staying at the site in Maduravoyal for the past two weeks.

Early on Sunday, Kuma-

ravel, the victim's father who also worked at the site, contacted the police and said his son was lying unconscious. The police recovered the body, which had injuries on the neck, and sent it to the Government Kilpauk Hospital for a post-mortem.

The police questioned Senthamizh, 18, of Kandachipuram. The police said she was in a relationship with Silambarasan, and she initially claimed he had died by suicide. However, the police said her state-

ments contained contradictions. Silambarasan's parents, who were allegedly inebriated at the time of the incident, did not fully cooperate with the investigation. The police have detained Senthamizh and Manikandan, a mason's assistant at the site, for further inquiry.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104, TeleMANAS 14416, and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050.)

Man held in Madurai for forcing Indian nationals into 'cyber slavery' in Cambodia

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

The Cyber Crime Wing of the Tamil Nadu Police has arrested a 35-year-old man from Madurai for allegedly trafficking Indian nationals to cyber scam compounds in Cambodia and forcing them into online fraud operations under conditions described as "cyber slavery".

The police identified the accused as Madhan Vadivel, who allegedly operated an international recruitment and trafficking network linked to organised cyber scam centres run by foreign nationals in Cambodia.

According to officials, the arrest was made following a complaint from a victim from Tirupattur district.

An inquiry conducted by the State Cyber Crime Investigation Centre (SCCIC) revealed that the victim had been lured with promises of a lucrative overseas job in Cambodia. The accused allegedly collected money from the victim, arranged travel documents, and facilitated his journey to Cambodia, where he was handed over to operators running cyber scam compounds. The victim was allegedly confined inside the compound and forced to engage in online financial fraud and cyber scam activities.

Key recruiter

The police said the victim later managed to escape, approached the Indian Embassy for assistance, and safely returned to India.

Further investigation revealed that Madhan Vadivel allegedly acted as a key recruiter and facilitator in trafficking Indian nationals

seeking overseas employment. Officials said he had been running multiple restaurants under the name 'Jallikattu' inside cyber scam compounds in Cambodia for the past few years and supplied Indian food to the trafficked victims lodged there.

The police also uncovered an extensive network allegedly involving foreign nationals operating scam centres, travel agents, immigration facilitators, and taxi drivers across Cambodia, Laos, and Vietnam. Through this network, hundreds of Indian nationals are suspected to have been trafficked over the past three years. The accused received commissions for each recruitment and trafficking operation.

A special team of police arrested the accused in Madurai. Mobile phones, SIM cards and passport-related documents linked to the case were seized for forensic examination. Officials said further investigation is under way to identify other victims and recruiters and trace financial transactions and international links connected to the cyber fraud and human trafficking network.

Director-General of Police, Cyber Crime Wing, Bala Naga Devi urged the public to remain vigilant and verify all overseas job offers only through authorised recruitment agencies and official government channels.

A list of registered recruiting agents can be found on: <https://emi-grate.gov.in/>. She also advised them not to trust job advertisements circulated on social media platforms, WhatsApp groups, Telegram channels, or unknown online contacts.

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I, N. ANNAMMA, W/o. Jacob Solomon A born on 14.10.1955 residing @ No.10, Madha Nagar, IAF Road, Via Selaiyur, Chennai - 600073 shall henceforth be known as V. ANNAMMA VARGHESE	Notice to the Respondent (w/o V.R-20-IA CPC)	THE TRAVANCORE SUGARS & CHEMICALS LTD. (A Kerala Government Company) Valanjiyattom P.O., Thiruvalla, Kerala - 686 104 Tele. Office: 0468-2610711, 2610712, 2610446 Email: travancorecsugars85@gmail.com Website: www.travancorecsugars.com
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ASTROLOGY	JUPITER TRANSITION Special Programme by Kalaimamani Harikesanallur Venkatraman in Zee Tamil TV 7 Am to 7.15 AM from May 20 to 31	Oushadhi The Pharmaceutical Corporation (I.M.), Kerala Ltd. (A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking) Kuttanellur, Thirissur-14. Ph: 0487-2459807, 2459843 Re-Tender / Re-E-Tender Notice P/07/2026-27 19.05.2026 Re-Tender and Re-E-Tenders are invited from eligible bidders for the Supply of Containers & Packing Materials and Raw Materials. You can download tender documents from www.etenders.kerala.gov.in & www.oushadhitender.com . For more details visit www.oushadhi.org or contact Purchase Department. (Sd/-) Managing Director

Indian Institute of Technology
Madras

IIT Madras has invited applications for its web-enabled M.Tech and PG Diploma programmes aimed at working professionals and recent graduates. For the M.Tech programme, the candidates should have relevant educational background and at least two years of work experience, while the PG Diploma programme is open to graduates, including freshers, with preference for those with relevant educational background. Those interested may submit their applications through the portal <https://code.iitm.ac.in/webtmtech>. The last date for submission of applications is May 31. The entrance exams are scheduled for June and July and selected candidates will start their academic sessions in August or September.

The Anna Nagar police have arrested a 19-year-old man for assaulting a woman in Anna Nagar after she refused to accept his marriage proposal. The victim, a resident of T.P. Chathiram, had been in a relationship with Vinoth, alias Stephen, of Maduravoyal, but later cut ties with him, the police said. On the night of May 15, while she was walking near the Anna Nagar roundabout after work at a textile store, the accused allegedly intercepted her and verbally abused her. He then assaulted and threatened to kill her, and then fled the spot. The injured woman informed her father and received treatment at the Government Kilpauk Hospital. Based on her complaint, the Anna Nagar police registered a case under the relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Tamil Nadu Prohibition of Harassment of Women Act. Following this, Vinoth was arrested and remanded in judicial custody.

Southern Railway eases speed restrictions after completing track rectification works

The Chennai Division identified sharp curves and undertook rail straightening works in Beach-Egmore, Egmore-Villupuram, Central-Arakkonam and Central-Gudur sections. This is part of efforts to improve line capacity and enhance operational flexibility of both suburban and long-distance trains

R. Srikanth
CHENNAI

Sharp curves on railway tracks, which act as speed breakers, hinder the operational efficiency of both suburban and long distance trains.

Permanent speed restrictions (PSR) are imposed to regulate train operations on stretches with sharp curves and prevent derailments.

In order to improve the operational efficiency by removing PSRs, the Chen-



Seeking action: A regular commuter is concerned over fast trains being operated on the slow line between Egmore and Beach.

nai Division identified infrastructure development and track straightening works in four sections.

A senior official of the Chennai Division said that as part of the sustained efforts towards improving line capacity and enhancing operational flexibility, the speed restrictions were relaxed in four sections – Beach-Egmore (where a fourth line was newly added), Egmore-Villupuram, Central-Arakkonam, and Central-Gudur.

The track straightening works involved track renewal, strengthening of formation, curve transition corrections, and continuous monitoring of track geometry.

Under the PSR relaxation procedure, the engi-

neering work was carried out between Beach and Egmore railway stations, Central-Jolarpettai route in the Central-Arakkonam section, between Chengalpattu and Villupuram, and on Nayudupeta-Doravari Chattram and Sullurupeta-Polireddipalem stretches in the Gudur section.

Speed raised

After carrying out the corrective measures, the permissible speed has been raised on these stretches. For long-distance trains, it has been increased from 110 kmph to 125 kmph.

The speed restriction on the main lines have also

been relaxed after correcting the curve geometry, facilitating smoother suburban train operations in these highly congested corridors.

T. Ramesh, a regular commuter from Perungalathur, said the fast trains operated from Chengalpattu to Beach were previously operated on the main line till Beach station. However, after a platform at Chennai Fort was dismantled for constructing the fourth line, all the fast line trains were being operated on the slow line from Egmore to Beach, he said, urging railway officials to find a solution.

Two airlines staff booked for ₹2.2-cr. fraud

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Two employees handling finances at the Chennai office of SriLankan Airlines allegedly misappropriated ₹2.20 crore by diverting company funds to multiple bank accounts using forged receipts and fabricated financial documents.

Efforts are under way to trace the accused.

Investigations have also uncovered a larger fraud, involving nearly ₹10 crore, linked to the airline's operations in Dubai and Chennai, prompting parallel

Investigations have uncovered a larger fraud, involving nearly ₹10 cr., linked to SriLankan Airlines' operations in Dubai and Chennai

probes in Dubai, Sri Lanka, and Chennai.

According to sources, a service provider engaged by SriLankan Airlines in Dubai informed the airline that payments worth nearly ₹8 crore had not been received. Airline officials, however, said the payments

had already been transferred based on email communication received from the vendor.

Subsequent inquiries revealed that unidentified cyber fraudsters had hacked the email account of the airline's service provider's and diverted the funds through fraudulent transactions.

Following the discovery, SriLankan Airlines filed complaints with the Criminal Investigation Department authorities in Dubai and Sri Lanka, leading to a detailed probe into the suspected cyber fraud.

In a separate complaint concerning the airline's Chennai office on Dr. Radhakrishnan Road, the company alleged that staff members responsible for financial transactions siphoned off ₹2.20 crore by creating fake payment records and forged receipts.

Preliminary investigations suggest that fabricated financial documents were used to facilitate the fraudulent transactions. Police teams are searching for employees suspected to be involved in the scam, while further investigations are under way.

Former taluk office clerk convicted in graft case

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A Special Court for cases under the Prevention of Corruption Act on Monday convicted a former junior assistant attached to the Mambalam-Guindy taluk office and a private individual in a 2011 bribery case.

The court sentenced the clerk, T.S. Murthy, to two-year rigorous imprisonment and his accomplice, N. Sugumar, to one-year rigorous imprisonment.

According to the Direc-

torate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption, the case was registered in 2011 based on a complaint by K. Jansi, alias Jansi Rani, of Virugambakkam.

The complaint said that when Ms. Jansi approached Murthy for a legal heir certificate, he allegedly introduced her to Sugumar and told her to pay the amount demanded by him. On March 10, 2011, Sugumar allegedly collected a bribe of ₹4,000 on behalf of Murthy, and gave her the certificate.

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INBRIEF



DRI recovers two Indian Red Sand Boa snakes in Telangana

Officials of the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), Hyderabad zonal unit, seized two live Indian Red Sand Boa snakes and apprehended a person during an operation in Warangal in Telangana on Sunday. Officials said specific intelligence inputs indicated that a person was attempting to sell live snakes in the grey market. The DRI conducted an undercover decoy operation on May 17 and intercepted the suspect at the identified location.

Naidu hails TTD for near 90% forest cover in Tirumala hills

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Monday congratulated the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) on achieving 89.40% forest cover in Tirumala through sustained conservation measures aimed at protecting forest wealth and restoring native species in the Seshachalam Hills. He, in a message on ‘X’ appreciated the TTD’s efforts, saying it would help preserve a greener and healthier Tirumala for future generations.

Three held in Telangana for killing two money lenders

An investigation into the murders of two women moneylenders in Telangana’s Vikarabad district on March 30 and May 4 has revealed that the accused couple had allegedly planned to kill several more lenders to wipe out debts of ₹10 lakh to ₹12 lakh, police said. The accused, Kareema, Rahman and Nayeem, were arrested by Tandur Rural police on Sunday. The murders came to light after technical surveillance tracked the a victim’s movements.

HC extends SIT probe by two weeks in Sabarimala gold theft case

The Kerala High Court has granted two more weeks to the Special Investigation Team (SIT) that has been probing the alleged misappropriation of gold from the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, to complete the entire exercise.

This followed the submission of a detailed report regarding the matter by S. Sasidharan, the investigating officer of the SIT, on Monday. In the report, the SIT has said that one of the principal reasons for the delay in completing the investigation is the non-receipt of the detailed analysis report from the National Metallurgical Laboratory (CSIR NML), Jamshedpur, where approximately 36 samples have been forwarded for scientific examination.

Reason for delay

The tests being conducted include X-ray Fluorescence Spectroscopy (XRF) for determining the surface elemental composition, Inductively Coupled Plasma Mass Spectrometry (ICP MS) for ultra trace impurity and elemental profiling, and Optical Emission Spectroscopy (OES) for analysing alloy composition and metallurgical uniformity. These are highly specialised tests which require time for completion.

The laboratory authorities informed the SIT that the final report is expected to be furnished within ten days. Only after receiving the report can the agency determine the extent of gold plating and quantity of goldthe SIT told the HC.

9 Indian space start-ups sign strategic partnerships in Italy

The nine Indian space-tech companies, including Astrogate Labs, Astrobase Space Technologies, VyomIC, Suhora, Kepler Aerospace Ltd., Hyspace Technologies, TakeMe2Space, Jarbits Pvt. Ltd. and Dhruva Space, joined the delegation, with multiple partnerships and collaborations at the recently held Space Meetings Veneto 2026 at Venice, Italy.

The Indian delegation also held strategic engagements with the Italian Space Industry Study Group to explore opportunities for deeper commercial and technological cooperation between the two countries.

IN-SPACe which is the single-window agency for all space sector activities of private entities said that

the nine Indian space-tech companies, including Astrogate Labs, Astrobase Space Technologies, VyomIC, Suhora, Kepler Aerospace Ltd., Hyspace Technologies, TakeMe2Space, Jarbits Pvt. Ltd. and Dhruva Space, joined the delegation, with multiple partnerships and collaborations at the recently held Space Meetings Veneto 2026 at Venice, Italy.

Among the key developments, Karnataka-based Astrobase Space Technologies signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Impulso Space to support customer access and explore launch opportunities through integrated mission management and launch service networks. Kepler Aerospace signed a framework

agreement with Apogeo Space to expand global Ground Station as a Service (GSaaS) infrastructure and strengthen satellite collaboration between India and Europe.

The partnership will further explore joint opportunities across CubeSat systems, satellite mission and infrastructure operations.

This visit follows the Italian Aerospace Delegation’s visit to India in 2025. IN-SPACe said that in alignment with the 2025-2029 India-Italy Joint Strategic Action Plan announced during the G20 Summit 2024, a bilateral meeting also took place.

It added that this will result in strengthening strategic collaboration between the two countries.

Health gains reversed by geopolitical challenges: Soumya Swaminathan

Nagesh Prabhu SINGAPORE

Soumya Swaminathan, chairperson of the M.S. Swaminathan Research Foundation, said on Monday that gains in global health achieved over recent decades are becoming increasingly fragile, while progress in maternal and child health is being reversed owing to geopolitical challenges and declining development funding.

‘Rise in violence’

Delivering the keynote address at the inauguration of the sixth annual Philanthropy Asia Summit (PAS) in Singapore, she said, “Some of the gains we have



made in maternal and child health are getting reversed because of geopolitics and loss of development funding in many countries.”

“Gender-based violence and domestic violence increase significantly with climate change, particular-

ly during prolonged periods of heat and drought. People have also reported lower incomes during summer,” she said.

Health and economy

Dr. Swaminathan said that many countries tend to focus on hospitals and primary healthcare centres when thinking about health systems, while overlooking the broader determinants of health, including social, environmental, and economic factors.

Highlighting the impact of climate change on public health, Dr. Swaminathan said, “I truly believe that climate change and all the threats we face today are not only about our

Cong. govt. in Karnataka to celebrate its 3 years in office

The government has also decided to increase the honorarium of ASHA workers by ₹3,000, raising it to ₹12,000. “I had gone to the protest venue of ASHAs in front of the Secretariat and told them that we will implement their demands one by one from the first Cabinet meeting onwards.

Amid continued clutter over the Congress leadership, the Chief Minister Siddaramaiah-led Congress government will celebrate the completion of three years on Tuesday with the ‘Pragathiyyatta Karnataka’ (Karnataka towards development) convention at Tumakuru in Karnataka.

“The convention will witness the distribution of certificates by the Revenue Department, and will have a celebration to mark the completion of three years. We gave a manifesto and promised to people that it would be realised in five years.” Home Minister G. Parameshwara said.

The Hindu Bureau THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Congress leader V.D. Satheesan was sworn in as the new Chief Minister of Kerala along with 20 Ministers at a ceremony held at a packed Central Stadium in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala on Monday. Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar administered the oath of office and secrecy to Mr. Satheesan and the Ministers-designate over a one-hour-long ceremony.

The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) had scripted a landslide victory over the Left Democratic Front (LDF) in the April 9 elections by claiming 102 of the 140 seats in the Assembly.



Triumphant arrival: V. D. Satheesan and Ramesh Chennithala on stage for the swearing-in ceremony on Monday. NIRMAL HARINORAN

Mr. Satheesan, 61, who was the Leader of the Opposition during 2021-2026, was the first to be sworn in. Mr. Arlekar presented Mr. Satheesan with a bouquet as the stadium drowned in cheers from the crowd. Congress leader Rahul

Gandhi greeted the new Chief Minister with a hug.

List of Ministers

Mr. Arlekar administered the oaths to other Ministers-designate and greeted all the members of the new Council of Ministers with

UDF rolls out 2 guarantees on first day: free bus travel for women, ASHA hike

is implementing schemes for senior citizens, as it has a model worth emulating,” Mr. Satheesan said.

The government has also decided to increase the honorarium of ASHA workers by ₹3,000, raising it to ₹12,000. “I had gone to the protest venue of ASHAs in front of the Secretariat and told them that we will implement their demands one by one from the first Cabinet meeting onwards.

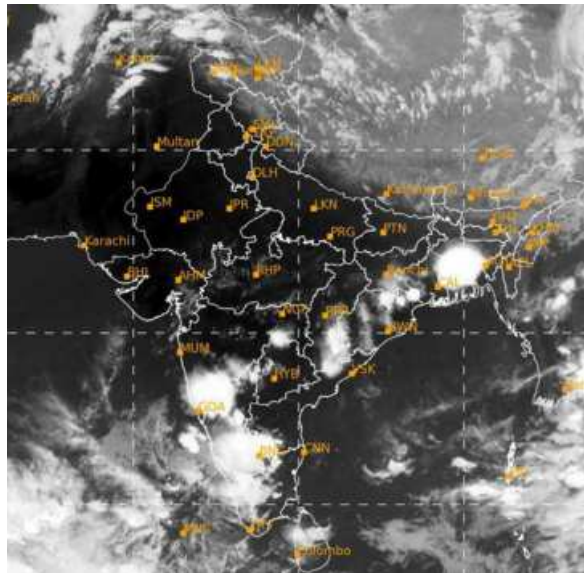
bouquets.

In taking the oaths, Mr. Satheesan was followed by Ministers-designate P.K. Kunhalikutty, Ramesh Chennithala, Sunny Joseph, K. Muralleedharan, Mons Joseph, Shibu Baby John, Anoop Jacob, C.P. John, A.P. Anil Kumar, N. Samsudheen, P.C. Vishnunadh, Roji M. John, Bindu Krishna, M. Liju, K.M. Shaji, P.K. Basheer, V.E. Abdul Gafoor, T. Siddique, K.A. Thulasi and O.J. Janeesh. All of them took the oath in Malayalam, except K. Muralleedharan who took the oath in English.

Chief Ministers and Ministers of various States and a large number of UDF members were present at the venue to witness the ceremony.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karaikal, Kerala, Mahe, Lakshadweep and Andaman & Nicobar Islands. Heat wave conditions likely at isolated places over Rajasthan, Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Bihar, Telangana and Vidarbha

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	
Agartala		46	29.9	20.3	Kozhikode	101	30.8	24.7
Ahmedabad			43.7	29.5	Kurnool	10	41.5	27.9
Aizawl		7	28.6	19.7	Lucknow		43.2	28.6
Allahabad			46.8	28.6	Madurai		37.0	25.2
Bengaluru		1.4	34.0	22.2	Mangaluru	14	31.1	24.2
Bhopal			44.0	28.5	Mumbai		34.1	27.4
Bhubaneswar			39.0	28.6	Mysuru		32.0	22.8
Chandigarh			41.8	27.2	New Delhi		43.4	26.3
Chennai			37.3	28.4	Patna		37.6	28.1
Coimbatore			34.1	24.0	Port Blair	19	31.7	24.2
Dehradun			38.9	22.6	Puducherry		34.6	27.2
Gangtok	37		22.7	15.6	Pune		41.8	26.0
Goa	11		34.3	25.0	Raipur		41.3	29.1
Guwahati	2		30.5	24.2	Ranchi		36.2	25.0
Hubballi			33.0	24.0	Shillong	7	23.8	15.0
Hyderabad			39.9	28.8	Shimla		32.2	18.4
Imphal	2		29.1	20.4	Srinagar		31.5	13.6
Jaipur			43.6	30.4	Thiruvananthapuram		32.0	25.9
Kochi	9		30.8	25.4	Tiruchi	0.5	37.3	25.6
Kohima			23.0	16.0	Vijayawada		39.2	28.0
Kolkata			38.4	29.0	Visakhapatnam		35.5	28.6

Pollutants in the air you are breathing										Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE				In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Charkhi Dabri, Bengaluru
Ahmedabad		22	100	24		52		115		Haryana recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 317
Bengaluru		9		24	48		70		87	indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Madikeri, Karnataka recorded a healthy AQI score of 15
Chennai		15		10	20		40		51	
Delhi		46	110	47		141		229		
Hyderabad		14		13	33		64		91	
Kolkata		11		25		7		51		
Lucknow		3		40	45		195		140	
Mumbai		3		10	52		26		90	
Pune		7		69	81		24		50	
Visakhapatnam		12		41	11		35		98	

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

E-TENDER NOTICE
Tender Notice No. : 09-MC-ROH-BOBRN-25-26-B, Dhanbad, dated : 14.05.2026
E-Open Tender in **Single Packet System** is invited in IREPS Portal for execution of the following work by Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer (Co-ord.), East Central Railway, Dhanbad:
1. Name of work : Outsourcing of Routine Overhauling (ROH) maintenance of BOBRN wagons at ROH Shed, BRWD.
2. Contract Period : 24 Months.
3. Location of work : ROH shed, BRWD, 4. Advertised Tender Value : ₹9,27,36,756/- (Rupees Nine Crore Twenty Seven Lakhs Thirty Six Thousand Seven Hundred Fifty Six Only)
5. Cost of Tender Document : ₹0.00 (Nil)
6. Earnest money (As per Nit) to be deposited : ₹18,54,700/- (Rupees Eighteen Lakh Fifty Four Thousand Seven Hundred Only)
7. Tender Publishing Date: 14.05.2026
8. Date & time for submission of E-Tender : From 22.05.2026 to 05.06.2026 up to 11:30 hrs.
9. Date & time of opening of E-Tender : 05.06.2026 at 12.00 hrs.
10. Website particulars : <http://www.ireps.gov.in> (No manual tender will be accepted against e-tendering.)
Sr. Divisional Mech. Engineer (Co-ord)/ ECR/Dhanbad
PR/0242/DHN/Mech./T/25-26/40

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
Office of the Dy Chief Electrical Engineer, Carriage Works / Electrical, Perambur, Chennai - 600 023.
E-Tender Notice No. E-E-29-I-2026-03-LIGHT
The bidders intending to log on to for e-tender for “WORKS TENDERS” need to get enrolled in the e-tender website <http://www.ireps.gov.in> and only online tenders will be accepted. The payment towards cost of Bid Security should be made only through online payment modes like net banking debit card/credit card etc., available on IREPS portal. It is the responsibility of the bidders to obtain necessary Digital Signature Certificates for participating in the e-Tender. Complete details and tender document will be available in at “<http://www.ireps.gov.in>”. For other details terms and conditions, the tenders are advised to refer to the documents uploaded. All Addendum / Corrigendum, time extension; clarifications etc., will be uploaded in the website only and will not be published separately in Newspapers. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.
Tenderers need not be present in the office for tender opening as they can watch the status of opened tenders on line IREPS.

Tender No. & Date : E-E-29-I-2026-03-LIGHT Dated : 15.05.2026
Name of the work : OW/PER - Provision of additional High - mast Lights and Street Lights at Railway Colonies, Perambur - Electrical Arrangements.
Approximate Tender value : Rs. 41,07,820/-
Last date and time of submission of e-tender : 10.06.2026 at 15.00 hrs
Period of completion : 180 days
AXEE / S / PER for Dy. CEE/CW/PER

Office of the Registrar, Co-operative Societies, Govt. of Jharkhand
Tender Notice for selection of Insurance Companies for implementation of Birs Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (B-PMFBY) for the seasons Kharif 2026, Rabi 2026-27, Kharif 2027, Rabi 2027-28, Kharif 2028and Rabi 2028-29 RFP No. 1120, Dated 18.05.2026
Office of the Registrar, Cooperative Societies, Jharkhand invites quotations from empanelled insurance companies by Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare, Govt. of India, for the implementation of the Birs Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (B-PMFBY) in 7 clusters consisting of 24 Districts under yield based crop insurance models viz. standard PMFBY, Cup and Cap 80:110 model and Cup and Cap 60:130 model. All empanelled Insurance Companies are mandated to get enrolled on <https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> in order to download the tender documents and participate in the subsequent bidding process. Bidders can also obtain the Tender Document and the draft Insurance Contract from the address given below or from the website <https://cooperative.jharkhand.gov.in>. The details of the proposed crop insurance covers, the instructions to bidders, the process of submission of bids and bid evaluation criteria have been set out in the Tender Document.
The department will follow the following schedule in respect of the Bid Process

1	Issuance of tender documents	18-05-2026
2	Start date of downloading of bid	19-05-2026
3	Submission of pre-bid queries	On or before pre-bid meeting date and time
4	Pre-bid meeting	25-05-2026, 11:30 AM
5	Last date and time of technical and financial bid submission	03-06-2026, 05:00 PM
6	Date of opening of technical bid	04-06-2026
7	Date of opening of financial bid	After technical evaluation
8	Date of issuance of notice of award	Will be intimated later

The completed Bid documents must be submitted before due date and time at <https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in/> Bidders should have valid Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) obtained from any licensed Certifying Authorities (CA).
The prospective bidder(s) should submit their pre-bid queries through email by the date as mentioned in the RFP schedule. Only suggestions/observations received in writing/email will be clarified and any modification of the RFP documents shall be made by Office of the Registrar, Co-operative Societies exclusively through the issue of an addendum/corrigendum. The RFP uploaded shall be read along with any modification. Authorized representatives of prospective bidder(s) can attend the said meeting and obtain clarification regarding specifications, works & RFP conditions.
The RFP document is available on www.cooperative.jharkhand.gov.in and <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> portal along with this Bid notice. However, the bidder shall have to pay “RFP Fee” (Non-Refundable) online on <https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> along with the bid.
Office of the Registrar, Co-operative Societies, Jharkhand shall not be liable for any omission, mistake or error in respect of any of the above or on account of any matter or thing arising out of or concerning or relating to the RFP or the Bidding Process, including any error or mistake therein or in any information or data given by the Authority.
The Office of the Registrar, Co-operative Societies, Jharkhand reserves the right to reject all or any of the bid(s) without assigning any reason at any stage.
Bidders shall note that any corrigendum issued regarding this bid notice/RFP will be published on the portal only. No corrigendum will be published in the local newspapers.
For any clarification, kindly contact
The Registrar, Office of the Registrar, Cooperative Societies Pashupalnevams Sankarita Bhawan Hesag, Ranchi, Jharkhand.
Email: jharkhand.coopregistrar@gmail.com
PR 380136 (Co-opretive)26-27-D

Sd/-Registrar Co-operative Societies, Jharkhand, Ranchi



Unlearnt lessons India's inadequate strategic petroleum and gas reserves stand exposed

Last week, the Centre hiked retail petroleum product prices after a gap of four years. This was expected, since the government had been warning about high crude prices, and how public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs) had been bleeding heavily due to under-recoveries. It was also expected that this would happen after the results of the five Assembly elections. But the Prime Minister's appeal for austerity due to the drain on foreign exchange, the sharp depreciation of the rupee in recent months and the April's inflation prints point to a much deeper problem that India could have addressed decades earlier – the country's inadequate strategic petroleum and gas reserves. India did build out a strategic petroleum reserve (SPR) of about 36.7 million-39 million barrels, a programme conceived following the post-1991 vulnerability and formalised in the early 2000s. But today, this covers about seven days of consumption demand at 5.5 million barrels per day (mbpd). Combined with inventories of OMCs and import cover, this amounts to more than 70 days of stock. But over the years, India has emerged as the world's third-largest automobile market after the U.S. and China, and a comparison with those nations reveals the scale of India's vulnerability.

While the U.S. built its SPRs in the aftermath of the 1973 oil shock – which, at 714 million barrels, is 18 times larger than India's – China's roughly 900 million barrels is even larger. The U.S. has about 400 million barrels currently in its reserve system, providing it with roughly 20 days of consumption. The country has emerged as the world's largest oil producer in the past 10 years with an output of about 13 mbpd and a commercial system wide inventory, pushing it above the 90 day-mark recommended by the International Energy Agency for reserves. The same applies to China, which is comparable with India as a more oil import-dependent nation. These numbers become even starker when compared with reserves for liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and liquefied natural gas (LNG), where India is most exposed. India has about 1.4 lakh tonnes of LPG storage, while its daily consumption is about 80,000 tonnes – more than half its reserve capacity. As for LNG, India largely relies on stocks at regasification facilities of Petronet LNG and BPCL, without any underground storage for a fuel vital to produce fertilizers. Both the U.S. and China have heavily invested in underground LNG storage. The EU was quick to adapt following the Russia-Ukraine war as it drew down its dependence on Russian gas. These reserves have enabled advanced economies to hedge against supply disruptions by relying on long-term contracts at times of supply disruptions, cushioning them from spot market spikes. As for China, its defiance of American sanctions against Russian oil has paid off handsomely. India would have benefited too, had it maintained greater strategic autonomy.

Waiting for the storm Despite the predictability of weather events, India remains vulnerable

Late last week, a pacy pre-monsoon weather system barrelled into Uttar Pradesh, bringing a compound of thunderstorms, dust storms, lightning, heavy rain, and thunder-squalls to multiple districts at once. By May 14, the toll was 111 deaths and 72 injuries across 26 districts, rendering the storms among the deadliest weather-related disasters in Uttar Pradesh in recent times. The State has experienced similar weather events in May-June since 2018, if not before. The distinction this year seems to have been the intensity, with winds capable of uprooting trees. The storm appears to have been driven by a pre-monsoon convective system, with a fresh western disturbance over the northwest further destabilising conditions. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) had issued thunderstorm and lightning alerts before the event and the Uttar Pradesh government reportedly issued more than 34 crore red and orange alert messages via the SACHET portal. However, it is not clear whether these warnings were sufficiently geographically precise or reached their intended beneficiaries in time – and in fact if they simply warned of impending adverse weather or carried instructions for people to act on.

Indeed, advance preparation is pertinent for two reasons. The State is sometimes in a convergence zone as the hot, dry, 'loo' winds from the Thar move east over the plains while moisture-laden winds from the Bay of Bengal push in from the southeast. Second, over the undulating Vindhya hills in Mirzapur and Sonbhadra, the convergent air masses may lift rapidly, producing thunderstorms over specific parts of the State. Effectively, while no authority could have predicted the storms' local intensity, the underlying risk was hardly unforeseeable. Their recurrence at this time of the year and place should raise sharp questions about why so many deaths still occurred. Part of the answer is surely the proximate causes of death and damage, including housing and public infrastructure. Uttar Pradesh has a large number of structurally vulnerable rural and peri-urban households. If a storm strikes at dusk or later, people are often indoors or resting under fragile roofs. In addition, people are also vulnerable to improperly placed or poorly installed hoardings, electrical wiring, and public signage. The State was aware of the kinds of damage such storms could cause as it announced separate relief packages depending on the type of farming, crop, and loss. The underlying risk was foreseeable, yet the vulnerability was high.

India's scientific ambitions are increasingly visible in space missions, pharmaceutical research, and peer-reviewed scholarship. Yet, its institutional culture that sustains this continues to marginalise many researchers. Women in academia, especially in mid-career stages, face a convergence of professional and domestic responsibilities that their male peers rarely experience to the same extent. Age relaxation provisions in research grants were introduced to address this gap, but as these policies evolve, they require closer scrutiny to improve their effectiveness rather than weaken them.

The legal foundation for gender-sensitive research policy in India is not merely permissive; it is, in important respects, directive. Article 15(3) of the Constitution allows the state to make special provisions for women and children, and this has long been read as enabling affirmative measures in employment and public opportunity. Article 16 reinforces equality of opportunity without precluding measures that correct historical disadvantage and read alongside the Directive Principles which speak of equal right to an adequate means of livelihood. There is a coherent constitutional argument that funding agencies have not just the authority but also a degree of responsibility to ensure women researchers are not structurally penalised for caregiving.

Article 51A(e), the fundamental duty to renounce practices derogatory to the dignity of women, adds another dimension. A policy environment that routinely produces grant cohorts with negligible female representation is not a neutral outcome – it reflects accumulated disadvantages that the constitutional framework obliges institutions to address.

The legislative gap at heart of the problem
The Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017 remains the most substantive legal protection available to women. The 2017 amendment extended paid maternity leave to 26 weeks for women with fewer than two surviving children and introduced provisions for crèche facilities in larger establishments. For women in academic research, this matters – but imperfectly. Many researchers at the postdoctoral or early career stage are employed on fellowships, project positions, or contractual appointments that fall outside the clear ambit of the Act.

Equally overlooked in current frameworks is the return to research after childbirth. Women returning from maternity leave often face disrupted laboratory work, changed collaborations, and misaligned grant timelines,



Nabeela Siddiqui

Assistant Professor,
Vinayaka Mission's
Law School, Vinayaka
Mission's Research
Foundation (Deemed
University), Chennai

The structural
gender gaps in
India's research
ecosystem must
be addressed

Strategic spark in India-South Korea defence ties

The visit of the Indian Defence Minister to Seoul (May 19-21), following the South Korean President's visit to India (April 19-21, 2026), underscores the growing momentum and strategic significance of the India-South Korea partnership in recent years.

What began as limited defence engagement has evolved into a multidimensional partnership in defence manufacturing, technology transfer, and military modernisation. The K9 Vajra-T programme, developed under the 'Make in India' initiative, has become the flagship project of India-South Korea defence cooperation, paving the way for several other successful initiatives.

Project areas

Today, bilateral defence cooperation is expanding rapidly, with several new projects under consideration. Submarine collaboration has emerged as a key focus area, driven by South Korea's expertise in conventional submarines, lithium-ion battery systems, and air-independent propulsion technologies through companies such as Hanwha Ocean. South Korea's advancing aerospace sector, including the KF-21 fighter programme and the FA-50 light combat aircraft, has opened new avenues for collaboration in fighter technologies, engines, avionics, missile integration, and maintenance systems.

As one of the world's leading shipbuilding powers, South Korea can significantly contribute to India's growing maritime ambitions in the Indo-Pacific through cooperation in destroyers, logistics vessels, submarine support systems, smart shipyards, and naval propulsion technologies.

Discussions are also progressing in areas such as light tanks, utility helicopters, future ready combat vehicles, military lithium batteries, and defence electronics. Indian and Korean defence firms are pursuing joint ventures and industrial partnerships across multiple sectors.

Importantly, the partnership is evolving



Lakhvinder Singh

Director of Peace and
Security Studies at
the Asia Institute in
Seoul, South Korea

Expanding
defence
cooperation will
reflect shared
regional security
priorities

with little formal support for reintegration or reduced workload. The expectation of immediate full productivity after childbirth is unrealistic and requires clear policy intervention rather than informal goodwill from supervisors.

India has no central legislation on paternity leave. Central government employees receive 15 days under the Central Civil Services (Leave) Rules, 1972, but this is administrative rather than statutory, and no comparable entitlement exists for researchers funded through extramural grants. This legislative asymmetry – generous maternity protection, minimal paternity provision – is not incidental. It shapes how institutions and funding agencies think about caregiving, and it partly explains why age relaxation policies have been designed exclusively around women rather than around the act of caregiving itself.

The case for women-specific support in research funding is supported by persistent data, not assumption. The All India Survey on Higher Education (2021-22) shows that the higher education system had nearly 16 lakh faculty in 2021-22 with 57% male and 43% female. Women remain underrepresented in faculty positions across central universities and especially in science and technology institutions. The Science and Engineering Research Board (SERB) has also reported consistently lower application and success rates among women researchers.

The pattern is clear. Women who complete doctoral degrees in their mid-to-late twenties enter postdoctoral work at the same time as peak domestic responsibilities. Balancing grant cycles, publication pressure, travel, and childcare is not shared equally in academic households. Studies on dual-career faculty, including at the Tata Institute of Social Sciences, show that women typically bear a greater share of domestic work regardless of professional status. The consequences are measurable: delayed publications, gaps in grant records, and reduced international visibility. Age relaxation, in this context, is a partial remedy for a documented structural disadvantage.

What the courts have suggested

The Supreme Court of India's reasoning in *Vijay Lakshmi vs Punjab University And Others* (2003) is relevant here. Addressing preferential provisions for women in service matters, the Court drew a clear distinction between formal equality and substantive equality, which accounts for unequal outcomes.

It held that measures favouring women are constitutionally valid when they address demonstrated disadvantages. This logic applies to

research grants as well: extending eligibility windows for women is not preferential treatment, but a corrective to structural disadvantage.

None of this implies that current policy is adequate. Age relaxation policies such as those under SERB address eligibility at the application stage but not the everyday conditions of research. A five-year extension to the upper age limit may allow women to apply for grants they would otherwise miss, but it does not provide childcare support during proposal writing, institutional support during maternity leave, or re-entry funding after career breaks.

There is also the question of who the policy excludes. A single father or a man caring for an ailing parent may also face significant career disruption, but the policy does not recognise him. This is not an argument to weaken protections for women, as evidence shows that caregiving burdens are not equal in Indian academia. Rather, it calls for an additional layer of support for documented caregiving responsibilities, while retaining and strengthening women-specific provisions that address the more widespread disadvantage.

What more considered policy would be

The National Education Policy 2020 gestures toward institutional flexibility and faculty wellbeing, but these commitments have not yet translated into binding research funding policy. That gap is overdue to be addressed. Funding agencies should consider no-cost grant extensions for documented caregiving periods, re-entry fellowships for women returning to research, and flexible milestone reporting for researchers with caregiving responsibilities. Several European research councils have implemented similar measures, showing that gender-neutral caregiving support, alongside gender-specific provisions, can improve equity without appearing arbitrary.

Gender-based age relaxation in Indian research grants is constitutionally grounded and empirically justified. The disadvantage it addresses is real, documented, and persistent. Removing it in the name of gender neutrality would be a policy error not supported by evidence. What is needed instead is a layered approach that retains support for women researchers while adding provisions for other caregivers. India's research institutions owe their women scholars not just formal access to grants but the structural conditions in which a sustained research career is genuinely possible. Age relaxation is a beginning. It should not be mistaken for an ending

growing missile and nuclear capabilities continue to pose a serious threat to South Korea, while expanding Russia-North Korea military cooperation is reshaping Northeast Asia's security architecture.

China's growing naval assertiveness around the Korean Peninsula has created new strategic concerns for South Korea. Beijing's expanding influence and military presence in the South China Sea also carry major implications for South Korea, as a significant share of its energy imports and maritime trade passes through these waters.

South Korea is also facing serious structural challenges. Its declining demographic profile and shrinking pool of military recruits are weakening the long-term sustainability of its conventional defence posture. Combined with a rapidly changing security environment, these internal vulnerabilities create a complex strategic situation requiring urgent and sustained policy attention from countries seeking long-term strategic cooperation with Seoul.

Need for a strategic convergence

In this context, it is essential for India's strategic thinkers and defence planners to pay closer attention to changing geopolitical realities in South Korea. Ignoring these developments could undermine both South Korea's security and India's broader Indo-Pacific interests.

If India seeks to substantially expand its defence-industrial cooperation with South Korea, it must recognise that such cooperation depends on South Korea's security, stability, and strategic resilience. Strengthening South Korea's ability to address its security challenges should be central to this partnership.

The Indian Defence Minister's visit to Seoul should lead to the beginning of a new phase in India-South Korea defence cooperation – one that moves beyond defence-industrial ties toward a broader partnership grounded in shared security interests and Indo-Pacific stability.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Beyond numbers

Raising the strength of Supreme Court judges from 33 to 37 is too modest to substantially clear the backlog of cases (Front page, May 18). Even if it is increased to 100, nothing will improve. The need of the hour is fixed timelines, better case filtering, fewer unnecessary adjournments, greater use of technology, and judicial reforms rather than just increasing the number of judges. People want not just justice, but

quick justice.
Kshirasagara Balaji Rao,
Hyderabad

The decision may offer temporary administrative relief, but it is unlikely to cure the deeper institutional malaise. Pendency is not merely a problem of numbers; it is a problem of judicial architecture. Former judges and legal scholars have repeatedly pointed to procedural delays, indiscriminate admission of appeals, prolonged

constitutional hearings, and the Court's transformation into a routine court of error rather than a constitutional court. Even with four additional judges, fresh filings may continue to outpace disposals. What India perhaps needs is structural reform – regional benches, stricter filtering of Special Leave Petitions, greater use of technology, and stronger High Courts. Without rethinking the court's role and functioning, expansion alone risks

becoming an endless arithmetic exercise.
Gopalaswamy J.,
Chennai

Poor maintenance

The recent fire incident on the Delhi-Thiruvananthapuram Rajdhani Express has once again raised concerns about passenger safety and the condition of coaches used on this prestigious train. Introduced in 1969, the Rajdhani Express was one of Indian Railways' premier

long-distance services. However, it is disappointing that many coaches now appear old and poorly maintained. I travelled in the first air-conditioned coach of this train a couple of years ago and experienced water seepage in the washroom and wash areas, clearly reflecting ageing infrastructure and inadequate upkeep. While the central government and Indian Railways continue to introduce new trains under

different categories, insufficient attention appears to be given to replacing ageing coaches in flagship services such as the Rajdhani. Passenger safety, comfort, and maintenance standards should never be compromised on trains carrying thousands of passengers over long distances.

S. Subhash,
Kayamkulam, Kerala

Letters emailed to
letters@thehindu.co.in
must carry the postal address.

A new political trajectory in Bihar

Jairam initiates privilege notice against Pradhan over ‘impugned’ remarks

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Jairam Ramesh, Congress Chief Whip in the Rajya Sabha, on Monday moved a privilege notice against Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan for his “derogatory” remarks that allegedly lowered the dignity of Parliament.

In his notice, Mr. Ramesh cited the Union Minister’s remarks at a press conference on May 15.

The Minister, responding to a question on why the government did not implement the recommendations of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education on the National Testing Agency (NTA), said, “I will not comment on Parliamentary Standing Committee red flags. I will speak about the High-Level Committee of Experts (HLCE)/Radhakrishnan Committee. The Parliament Standing Committee has members from the Opposition. They write things in a certain manner; you also know that. Hence, I won’t speak on the standing committee.”

Mr. Ramesh said these “derogatory” comments revealed the Minister’s “contempt for Parlia-



House row: Dharmendra Pradhan’s comments lowered the dignity of Parliament, says Jairam Ramesh. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR/PTI

ment”. “He has made these outrageous remarks while presiding over the rot in the Education Ministry that is destroying the future of lakhs of youth across the country,” he said in a post on X.

He said the parliamentary committees were an extension of Parliament and were rightly referred to as mini-Parliament. “They [comments] are highly derogatory and seek to malign parliamentarians, parliamentary committees and the Parliament of India,” he said. He also underlined that members of a parliamentary standing committee were drawn from all political parties.

“The Minister’s impugned comments clearly indicate and reveal his contempt for the Parliament, parliamentary commit-

tees, members of the parliamentary committee that are drawn from all political parties and India’s constitutional democracy itself,” the former Union Minister said.

Mr. Ramesh said Mr. Pradhan had “deliberately lowered the stature and prestige of the institution of the standing committee simply because of its bipartisan nature”.

“The Minister’s comments are also tantamount to imputing dishonourable motives to members of parliamentary committees themselves,” he said, and added, it was well established that any derogatory references to parliamentary committees or members of parliamentary committees constituted a “gross contempt” of parliamentary committees.

India now free from Naxalism, says Home Minister at Bastar

Shah was on his first visit since March 31, the deadline set by Centre to eliminate Left-wing extremism from country; laying down road map for development, he says whatever Bastar lost over decades will be restored in the next three to five years

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

Hailing the sacrifices of security forces in the decades-long battle against Naxalism, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday proclaimed that the country was “free” from Naxalism.

“I am declaring with pride, India is now Naxal-free,” the Home Minister said in Bastar, where he was on his first visit after March 31, a date the Centre had earlier decided as a deadline to eliminate Left-wing extremism from the country.

Mr. Shah laid down a road map for the development of the region and said that whatever Bastar, once the citadel for Maoists in the country, had lost in decades would be brought back in the next three to five years.

Addressing an audience comprising personnel involved in anti-Naxal operations, along with the family members of security personnel and civilians who lost their lives in Naxal violence, Mr. Shah credited the bravery of the forces



Paying homage: Home Minister Amit Shah offers floral tributes to soldiers who lost their lives in anti-Naxal operations at the ‘Amar Vatika’ memorial in Jagdalpur, Chhattisgarh, on Monday. ANI

for meeting the objective of a Naxal-free India.

“There is hardly any force in the country whose jawans have not laid down their lives... From 1971 till 2026, the public suffered it like a nightmare. A lot of bloodshed took place. Three generations got wasted. I am very happy that our target which could not be finished in a lifetime was achieved by our brave jawans in three to four years,” he said.

Mr. Shah said the country was by and large free

from security challenges of Jammu and Kashmir, the Northeast and Naxalism, problems it was facing in 2014 when the Narendra Modi-led government assumed power at the Centre.

‘70 service centres’

Earlier, Mr. Shah inaugurated the first security camp-turned-public service centre at a remote village in Bastar district and said 70 out of the total 196 security camps located in the erstwhile Maoist-affect-

ed areas of the State would be transformed into such centres over the next year and a half. These centres are named after freedom fighter Veer Gundadhar.

Mr. Shah said that when the government resolved to end Naxalism, the objective was not only to eliminate Naxalites but also to provide the poor tribal people of the region with all the facilities available in cities, so that their children can have a bright future.

“For decades, the Naxalites spread the misconcep-

tion that they have taken up arms because there has been no development. The truth is that this region has not developed because the Naxalites took up arms. Within a year, our government will bring all the development work done in Raipur to your villages. You have the same right to every government facility as the people of big cities,” the Minister added.

On Monday, Mr. Shah also felicitated senior Telangana police officers in Jagdalpur, Chhattisgarh, for their role in making Telangana a Naxal-free State.

The officers honoured included Telangana Director-General of Police C.V. Anand, State Security Advisor B. Shivadhar Reddy, Director-General of Police (Operations) Anil Kumar, and Malkajigiri Commissioner B. Sumathi, along with the State Intelligence Bureau team led by her.

At the event, he said Naxalism had never been confined to one region and had remained a matter of national concern, including in his home state of Gujarat.

(With inputs from The Telangana Bureau)

Centre hid fuel crisis ahead of polls, says Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Monday accused the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi of “hiding” the state of the economy before the Assembly elections as that would have damaged their poll prospects. Mr. Kharge alleged the Centre lacked foresight and had concealed the impact of rising prices until the conclusion of the elections, after which fuel and commodity prices began going up.

His remarks came a day after the Centre raised CNG prices for the second time in a week. The hike followed Friday’s increase in petrol and diesel prices by ₹3 a litre, attributed to rising global crude oil prices amid the U.S.-Israel war on Iran.

“The poor in the country are not even able to get the essential goods they deserve,” Mr. Kharge said.

Zero tolerance towards attack on police personnel, says Bengal CM

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari on Monday said that at least 40 persons had been arrested over the Park Circus violence incident.

Meanwhile, the number of persons apprehended in Friday’s violence in Asansol has increased to 26.

Mr. Adhikari, who met police personnel injured in Sunday’s violence at the office of the Deputy Commissioner of Police at Park Circus, issued a strict warning to protesters. “I am giving a clear message that there will be zero tolerance towards this kind of unrest, hooliganism and anti-national, anti-social activities. We will not allow such things to continue,” the newly elected Chief Minister said. He met with Kolkata Police officers, South-east Division, to assess law and order in the area.

“We will give you complete support to stop



Offering support: West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari meeting injured CRPF personnel in Kolkata on Monday. ANI

this. Any democratic movement is always welcome, but hooliganism is not allowed by us... Stay strong and we will give you full cooperation. Raising hand on the police will not be allowed by the present government,” Mr. Adhikari said. Six police personnel were injured in Sunday’s violence.

This came after violence broke out on Sunday afternoon after a crowd gathered at the seven-point crossing of the Park Circus area in the heart of Kolkata

to protest several issues, including restrictions on prayers on roads and the crackdown with bulldozers, in the past two weeks since the BJP government took charge.

“Do not think old rules still apply. If anyone believes the police force will continue to function with tied hands, they are mistaken,” the Chief Minister warned.

On Friday night in Asansol, tensions flared after a mob allegedly pelted stones and vandalised a

police post following complaints against the decibel level of loudspeakers at a mosque.

“A total of 26 accused persons were arrested and produced before the Ld. Court today. Of them, seven accused have been remanded to police custody, while 19 have been sent to judicial custody,” the Asansol-Durgapur police said in a statement on Sunday.

The police said they were investigating further, and planned to arrest other miscreants involved in the violence. Damages would be assessed and compensation taken from the miscreants remanded in connection with the vandalism, the police said.

Modernising police

Proposing modernisation of the police force within six months, Mr. Adhikari urged the Central government to retain 40 companies of Central paramilitary forces in West Bengal for some more time.

‘Political decision must on cut-off for mid-term polls under the simultaneous election system’

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A decision on the definition of the “remainder of the term” of the Lok Sabha or the Assemblies before an election is held will be a political one to be taken in consultation with political parties, P.P. Choudhary, Chairman of Joint Parliamentary Committee on simultaneous elections, said on Monday.

“Assuming the government loses majority after two-and-a-half years, mid-term election for the remaining two-and-a-half years’ period can be held. However, a decision has to be made for a situation when the majority is lost with six months or three months left before the end

of the term. The decision to have a cut-off time to determine the remainder of the term will have to be a political one in consultation with parties,” Mr. Choudhary told presspersons here.

He was speaking after holding consultations with various stakeholders on the Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, 2024 and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill on the issue of simultaneous elections.

He suggested that an amendment to anti-defection legislation would be required while President’s Rule can be applied for the remainder of the term.

Asked about a situation where a fractured mandate prevents formation of go-



P.P. Choudhary

vernment, Mr. Choudhary said that there is a mechanism to resolve it.

“Fractured mandate can be in any system. Various suggestions have come on how the synchronisation can be achieved.

Discussions are under way on the remainder of term.”

Pointing out that the Constitution’s 93rd amendment for local bodies that has addressed the remainder of the term, Choudhary said, “When that can be achieved at the grass-roots level, why cannot it be incorporated in State Assemblies and Parliament? There could also be a possibility of electing a Chief Minister by the Assembly.”

Old dilemma

“Nowhere in the world you see elections taking place for five or six Assemblies every year. Every one is affected in the chain. Programmes are not reaching people. Teachers are burdened with election work.

It is important for elections to be conducted together.” He pointed out that general elections and elections to State Assemblies were conducted simultaneously in four elections between 1952 and 1967.

To another question on whether it was going to be ‘One Nation-One Party’ system, Mr. Choudhary asked, “Do you think what happened between 1952 and 1967 was for one party? It is not being proposed by the Prime Minister [Narendra Modi]. The Election Commission had recommended it in 1980; Law Commission of India has recommended thrice in the past; and Parliamentary Standing Committee has recommended simultaneous elections in 2015.”

CENTRAL ELECTRICITY REGULATORY COMMISSION
6th, 7th, & 8th Floor, Tower-B, World Trade Centre,
Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029

Petition No. 121/TL/2026

Dated: 13.5.2026

NOTICE UNDER CLAUSE (a) OF SUB-SECTION (5) OF SECTION 15 OF THE ELECTRICITY ACT, 2003

An application under Sections 14 & 15 of the Electricity Act, 2003 (the Act) has been made by **SR and ER Power Transmission Limited**, B-9, Qutab Institutional Area, Katwaria Sarai, New Delhi – 110016 to establish the inter-State transmission system for the “Strengthening between SR Grid and ER Grid” (hereinafter referred to as “the Project”) on a Build, Own, Operate and Transfer Basis consisting of the following elements:

S. No.	Name of the Transmission Element	Scheduled COD as per Gazette Notification	% of Quoted Transmission Charges recoverable on the Scheduled COD of the Element of the Project	Element(s) which are pre-required for declaring the commercial operation (COD) of the respective Element
1.	Angul – Srikakulam 765 kV 2nd D/C line with 240 MVAR SLR at both ends on both circuits 765 kV line bays-2 Nos. GIS (at Srikakulam) 765 kV line bays – 2 Nos. AIS (at Angul) 765 kV, 240 MVAR SLR at Srikakulam-2 Nos. (6x80 MVAR switchable units) 765 kV, 240 MVAR SLR at Angul-2 Nos. (7x80 MVAR switchable units incl. 1 spare unit)	30 months (3.8.2028)	97.50	-
2.	1x330 MVAR, 765 kV bus reactor (3rd) at Angul Substation 765 kV bus reactor-1 No. (3x110 MVAR switchable units) 765 kV bus reactor bay-1 No.		2.50	-

Notes:

i. **POWERGRID** shall provide space (free of cost) for 2 Nos. of 765 kV line bays each at Srikakulam (GIS) and Angul for termination of Angul-Srikakulam 765 kV D/C line.

ii. **POWERGRID** shall provide space (free of cost) for 1x330 MVAR bus reactor along with associated bay at Angul.”

2. The Central Transmission Utility of India Limited, vide its letter dated 17.2.2026, has recommended for the grant of a transmission licence to the applicant to establish the proposed transmission system.

3. Based on the material available on the record, the Commission vide order dated 13.5.2026 in Petition No. 121/TL/2026, has proposed to issue a transmission licence to the applicant for the establishment of the transmission scheme as noted in para 1 above.

4. A copy of the application, along with its annexures and enclosures, made by the applicant for the grant of an inter-State transmission licence to **SR and ER Power Transmission Limited**, before the Commission can be accessed at the www.powergrid.in/subsidiaries or inspected by any person in the Commission’s office by following the laid down procedure.

5. Notice is hereby given in pursuance of clause (a) of sub-section (5) of Section 15 of the Act that suggestions or objections, if any, to the Commission’s proposal to grant a transmission licence to the applicant, as aforesaid, be sent to the undersigned by **23.5.2026** at the above noted address. The suggestions or objections received after the specified date shall not be considered.

6. The application shall be taken up for the further hearing by the Commission on **25.5.2026**. Any person who files suggestions or objections may in his/her discretion attend the hearing, for which no TA/DA shall be paid by the Commission.

Sd/-
(Harpreet Singh Pruthi)
Secretary

A CH-CHE

INBRIEF



13 killed in truck-container vehicle collision in Palghar

Thirteen people were killed and 20 injured in an accident in the Dhanivari region of Palghar district in Maharashtra on Monday, when a truck and a container vehicle collided on the Mumbai-Ahmedabad highway. According to the police, the truck was carrying at least 40 people from the Bapugaon region to Dhanivari for an engagement ceremony. The vehicle was travelling allegedly on the wrong side of the carriageway at the time of the accident and collided with the container lorry. A motorcycle was also caught in the accident, a statement by the Palghar district administration said. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis announced an *ex gratia* of ₹5 lakh each to the kin of the deceased.

Current risk of Ebola in India minimal, says Health Ministry

The Union Health Ministry has clarified that there was no reported case of Ebola in India and the current risk to the country remained minimal. The statement was issued on Monday with the Ministry noting that close monitoring of the recent outbreak of Ebola Virus Disease caused by the Bundibugyo virus strain in parts of the Democratic Republic of Congo and Uganda was being maintained. The WHO has declared the situation as Public Health Emergency of International Concern. “As a matter of abundant caution, surveillance and preparedness measures are being strengthened at points of entry and within the public health system,” said an official.

Two church bodies offer to broker peace between Kukis and Nagas

Leaders of two church organisations meet Manipur Chief Minister Khemchand Singh in a bid to end the conflict between the two communities in the State; truck drivers stranded on highways demand security escorts to reach their destinations

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Two church organisations have offered to broker peace between the Kukis and Nagas in ethnic conflict-scarred Manipur amid a “total shutdown” and an “economic blockade” affecting normal life across the State.

A 10-member team of church leaders, representing the Council for Baptist Churches in North East India (CBCNEI) and the Manipur Baptist Convention (MBC), called on Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh on Monday to discuss the tense situation between the two tribal communities.

According to an official at the Chief Minister's Office, the church leaders volunteered to facilitate peace between the two communities. They offered to engage two teams for the purpose. While one team will travel to the Kuki-dominated Kangpokpi district, the other will travel to the Naga-majority Senapati district, which borders Nagaland.

More than 40 Nagas and Kukis were held hostage af



Women from Naga, Meitei and Nepali communities stage a joint protest in Imphal demanding the immediate release of six civilians allegedly abducted by Kuki militants on Monday. ANI

ter unidentified gunmen killed three church leaders, belonging to the Thadou community, at Zero Point between Kotlen and Kotzim villages in Kangpokpi district on May 13.

A section of the Thadous resents being clubbed as Kuki, a set of tribes perceived by many non-Kukis as non-indigenous.

“The role being played by the church leaders in trying to defuse the situation arising out of the hostage crisis is laudable,” the

Chief Minister said, encouraging the CBCNEI and MBC to convince leaders of both communities.

“Hostages on both sides need to be released on humanitarian grounds urgently. Apart from talking to the Kuki community and church leaders, our team will travel to Kangpokpi to meet the family members of the three slain church leaders,” a CBCNEI spokesperson said.

The church team will then travel to Senapati to meet Naga church leaders

and key members of civil society organisations to discuss the prevailing situation and hostage crisis.

On May 15, various Kuki and Naga groups released 28 hostages – 14 each from both communities. The families and organisations of the two communities have been demanding the release of the remaining captives for peace to be ushered in.

Truckers’ appeal
Hundreds of goods-laden and empty trucks have

been stranded on highways in the State's Imphal Valley and Senapati district since a Kuki organisation imposed a “total shutdown” on May 13. The situation escalated after a Naga organisation enforced an “economic blockade” in Naga-inhabited areas on Sunday evening.

National Highway 2, the lifeline of Manipur, meanders through Senapati and Kangpokpi districts, connecting Imphal with the rest of the country.

“We have been stuck for the past five days and are facing an acute shortage of food and drinking water. Some people helped us with rice and *dal*, but that is not enough,” a group of drivers of the stranded commercial vehicles said, appealing to the Manipur government to ensure their safe passage.

The truck drivers also sought security escorts to reach their respective destinations.

A Manipur government spokesperson said the security forces continued their search for the missing persons. He said combing operations were being carried out in Kangpokpi and Senapati districts.

Justice Varma case: inquiry panel submits probe report

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Judges Inquiry Committee investigating allegations against Justice Yashwant Varma – against whom impeachment proceedings were initiated over the discovery of unaccounted cash from his official residence during a fire – submitted its report to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday.

The report, which was presented in accordance with statutory requirements under the Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968, will be laid before both Houses of Parliament in due course, officials said.

The three-member inquiry committee was constituted by the Speaker on August 12, 2025.

During a fire that broke out in the official residence of Justice Varma on the night of March 14, 2025, firefighters discovered massive amounts of burnt currency inside a storeroom.

An in-house committee constituted by former Chief Justice of India Sanjiv Khanna concluded that Justice Varma had “active or tacit control” over the specific storeroom where the cash was hidden.

In July 2025, over 200 MPs signed a motion to impeach the judge.

‘Cockroach’ remark spawns a satirical political outfit

Amarjot Kaur
CHANDIGARH

On May 16, 30-year-old Abhijeet Dipke posted a Google form on X inviting people to register for the “Cockroach Janta Party” – a satirical political outfit born a day after Chief Justice of India Surya Kant drew criticism over his “cockroach” remark.

Though Chief Justice Kant later clarified that his oral observation was directed at those using fake degrees to enter professions such as law and media, and not at unemployed youth, the remark had already struck a nerve online.

Within hours, Abhijeet received over 5,000 registrations, transforming an Internet joke into an unofficial organisation channelling public discontent, humour, and political frustration.

“The Cockroach Janta Party expresses the dissent of young people against



Abhijeet Dipke, founder of Cockroach Janta Party, and, right, the mascot of the online outfit. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



the statement made by the Hon'ble CJI, where he labelled the youth as cockroaches and parasites. It was unacceptable in a democracy like India, where the CJI of the Supreme Court, who is supposed to be the custodian of the Constitution and free speech, demeaned young people for their criticism,” says Abhijeet, who is in the U.S., completing his Master's degree in public relations at Boston University. He had previously vol-

unteered with the social media team of the Aam Aadmi Party from 2020 to 2023.

Sending a message

“The name ‘Cockroach Janta Party’ shows that we own the identity of the cockroach – if that is what it takes for young people to be heard. It also seeks to send a message that cockroaches exist only in filth and rot. This means the country's system has become so rotten that the

cockroaches now have to emerge,” he says.

A quick glance at the Cockroach Janta Party's website gives an overview of its mission and vision. “We are not here to set up another PM CARES, holiday in Davos on the taxpayer's salary slip, or rebrand corruption as ‘strategic spending’. We are here to ask – loudly, repeatedly, in writing – where the money went,” its website reads. With its tagline as “Voice of the lazy and unemployed”, the Cockroach Janta Party claims to represent the people that “the system forgot to count”. With zero sponsors and five demands, it identifies as “one large, stubborn swarm”.

As on May 18, Abhijeet claims this “swarm” has grown into a collective of over 50,000 people who have met the four-point eligibility criteria – unemployed, lazy, chronically online, and can rant professionally – to become

members of the Cockroach Janta Party.

“The vision is still evolving. Ideologically, we are a secular, socialist, democratic, and anti-caste organisation. Our ideology is inspired by Gandhi, Ambedkar, and Nehru,” says Abhijeet.

Five-point manifesto

The party's five-point manifesto puts the spotlight on the institutions of democracy. Apart from 50% reservation of all Cabinet positions for women, its manifesto includes a 20-year ban on MLAs and MPs who defect from one party to another, investigating the bank accounts of “*godi media*” anchors, arresting the CEC under the UAPA if any legit vote is deleted, and barring post-retirement Rajya Sabha appointments for any Chief Justice.

The Cockroach Janta Party introduces India to a long tradition of counter-cultural political movements that have used sa-

tire, absurdity, and performance to critique mainstream politics. In the U.S., the trend emerged in the 1960s through the Freak Power movement led by Hunter S. Thompson and the Youth International Party, or Yippies, founded by activists Abbie Hoffman and Jerry Rubin. In the early 2000s, Sweden witnessed the emergence of the Pirate Party, which channelled Internet culture and anti-establishment sentiment into a campaign for digital rights, privacy, and civil liberties.

Abhijeet hopes that this movement will tap into the concerns, needs, and hopes of the young population of India. “We are asking the nation to confront the reality that today's youth is losing hope in the system because it is no longer serving them, listening to them, or even seeing them. And the longer the system ignores this, the bigger the frustration will grow,” he says.

SC asks CBI to furnish ‘classified’ documents to former RAW official

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday directed the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to furnish “typed copies” of certain “sensitive” documents to a retired Army officer facing trial under the Official Secrets Act, 1923, for allegedly exposing irregularities within the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) in a book published in 2007.

A Bench of Justices J.K. Maheshwari and Atul S. Chandurkar observed that claims of confidentiality could not be invoked to deny the accused access to documents forming the basis of the prosecution, particularly when such material was integral to his defence. “When the demand for the documents was made by the accused

himself, which is being used against him in a court proceeding, such documents ought to be supplied... we direct that the documents as referred to in the application be supplied for his defence within two months,” it said.

The court was hearing a petition filed by Major-General V.K. Singh (retd), who had alleged irregularities within the RAW in his 2007 book *India's External Intelligence: Secrets of Research and Analysis Wing (RAW)*, published shortly after his retirement.

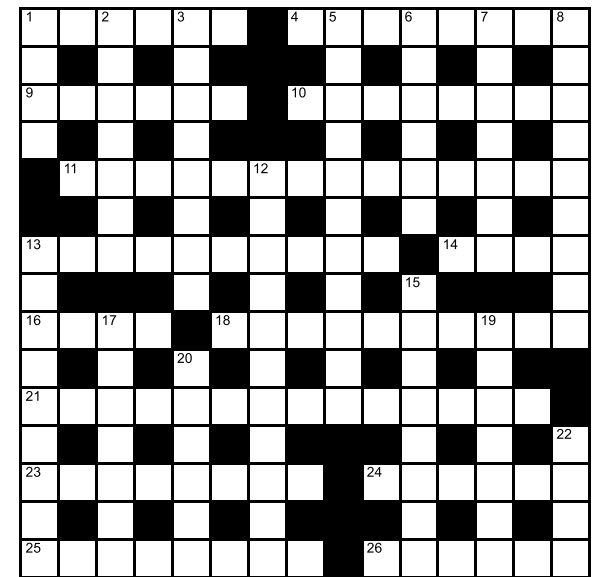
The CBI alleged that Mr. Singh, while serving as Joint Secretary in the Cabinet Secretariat (RAW) between November 2002 and June 2004, had access to classified information relating to the intelligence agency in the course of his official duties.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14797

(set by Avtaar)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- 11 Following mushy, thick paella Avtaar will calm down (4,1,5,4)
- 13 Savoury can be chosen after starter for dinner (10)
- 14 Ebbing river that is close to Warsaw Embankment (4)
- 16 Show rear end of catheter removed from ass (4)
- 18 Menacing coach upset by stragglers, finally isolated places for late-comers? (10)
- 21 Chemical from mobile charging distorted resolution (14)
- 23 Male model exposed retrograde tendency to play favourites (8)
- 24 Round table made flat on both sides (6)
- 25 Confirming result briefly on phone (8)
- 26 Afternoon school's principal visiting faculty nowhere to be seen (6)
- Down
- 1 Deposit left in knife dropped down (4)
- 2 Spike in upwardly mobile Mongolian Bohemians (7)
- 3 Old coins from Britain embodying earliest signs of unusually lavish luxury (8)
- 5 Bent lever is lit to control pressure in instrument (6,5)
- 6 Flyer to Rio leaving borders (6)
- 7 Party embracing the essence of quick unaided execution (7)
- 8 Hosts in stadium having come cycling (9)
- 12 President Brown visited by leader in Idaho introducing a boy (11)
- 13 Work out ending in Korean cinema about absolute authority (9)
- 15 Shortened course before spot of baked dessert (8)
- 17 Amidst work, actor uncovered organisation with extensive network (7)
- 19 Model again exercising, perhaps with energy, letting pressure off (7)
- 20 Siren's topless photograph linked to her missing husband (6)
- 22 Do without cocaine for semifinal run, say (4)

- Across
- 1 Almost relaxed about conducting children's drill (6)
- 4 Recurrent mistake inhibiting No.1 in Open American championship (8)
- 9 Delivery of the French whiskeys reduced by 50% (6)
- 10 Non-combatant John defending criminal vilified after disappearance of female editor (8)

SUDOKU

5	6		9					
1	7						9	
		9						1
			7	2		1	4	
	3		6		9		7	
	2	7		3	1			
3						4		
	4						6	9
					3		1	8

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Varaha avatar significance

Lord Narayana descends in every yuga to protect the righteous and destroy the forces of evil. In the Bhagavad Gita, He declares: *Paritrانaya Sadhunam, Vinasaya Cha Dushkritam, Dharma Samsthapanarthaya Sambhavami Yuge Yuge*. (The Lord incarnates in every age to protect devotees, destroy evil, and re-establish dharma.) Lord has three chakras associated with Him to protect us – Sudarsana Chakram, Jagath Chakram and Kalachakram.

In one of his discourses, Sri Velukkudi Krishnan Swamy emphasised that while material wealth naturally passes on to the next generation through inheritance, bhakti and spiritual wisdom should be instilled in children from a young age. That is the greatest inheritance parents can offer. Among the four yugas, many divine incarnations of Bhagavan appeared during Krita Yuga, including Matsya, Kurma, Varaha, Narasimha and Vamana.

The significance of Varaha avatar has been glorified by saints and acharyas such as Ramanuja, Nammazhvar and Parasara Bhattar. Lord explains that through His divine power, Maya Shakti, all beings move according to their karma. Yet among them, those who surrender to Him with devotion are especially protected by Him.

The central teaching of the Varaha avatar is that spiritual duties and practices meant for a particular stage of life should be performed at the proper age itself, rather than postponed till old age. Lord Varaha assures that if a devotee sincerely prays to Him while he is healthy, the devotee will be remembered and protected by Him in his final moments, ultimately guiding him toward the supreme abode, Vaikuntha.

INBRIEF



Nifty closes flat, most stocks decline on costly oil

The benchmark Nifty 50 closed flat even as oil prices soared to \$110 a barrel and the rupee depreciated to ₹96.2 against the U.S. dollar on Monday. The headline numbers showed a marginal 0.03% increase in Nifty which closed at 23,649.95 points. Investors sold massively, pulling the index by 1.18% by around 10:00 a.m. The selling was, however, compensated by buying, as IT sector stocks had become cheaper, making it the only sectoral index that gained more than 2.4% at closing. Of all the 21 sectoral indices, 13 declined, with some of them slipping more than 1.9%. The top five stocks on Nifty 50 were concentrated on two sectors – banking and technology. Further, nearly 70% of the 3,414 stocks that traded, declined.

Fertiliser subsidy bill for FY27 may rise by ₹70,000 crore

The government’s fertiliser subsidy bill for 2026-27 may surge by ₹70,000 crore to ₹2.41 lakh crore, driven by rising import costs of urea and other fertilisers amid the ongoing West Asia crisis, a senior official said on Monday. Aparna S. Sharma, Additional Secretary, Department of Fertilisers, on the sidelines of inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia developments, said, “The subsidy bill will go up, but what percentage is something I cannot say.” On whether the increase could be as much as ₹70,000 crore, she said, “may be.” The budgetary allocation for fertiliser subsidies in 2026-27 stands at ₹1.71 lakh crore. Despite the cost pressures, Sharma said fertiliser availability for the 2026 kharif season remains “comfortable”, with stocks exceeding 51% of the total requirement of 390 lakh tonne, the gap being bridged through diversified import sourcing. Current fertiliser stocks stand at 200.9 lakh tonne. Domestic production is running at approximately 80,000 tonne a day. PTI

Rupee declines to 96.2 against U.S. dollar as crude soars

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Indian rupee crossed the psychological mark of 96 a dollar, closing at 96.2, according to data from the Clearing Corporation of India (CCIL), even as Brent crude prices continued to increase.

The foreign exchange rate is up 6.3% since January 1, 2026. The depreciation is primarily due to the increase in oil prices with Brent Crude Futures at \$110.8 a barrel and WTI Crude Futures at over \$102.7 a barrel.

Foreign funds have withdrawn more than ₹2 lakh crore in equities, adding pressure to the depreciating rupee. In May alone, foreign institutional investors sold ₹24,829 crore in equities. The outflow is expected to continue and will put a lot more depreciation pressure on the rupee, said analysts.

“The broader trend for the rupee remains weak, with markets closely watching India’s strategic efforts to secure lower-cost oil and gas supplies to ease pressure on the import bill and forex reserves. Continued FII selling and global risk aversion are also adding to volatility in the currency market. Technically, rupee support is now seen near 96.55, while immediate resistance is placed around 96.00-96.10,” said Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst – Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities.

Diesel shortage chokes truck movement in several pockets

Supply chain distribution hit as truckers complain of lack of fuel availability or diesel supply restricted to about ₹5,000 worth of fuel at a time; dealers flag halting of credit facility by oil firms

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Even as the Union Government and oil marketing companies are claiming that there is no shortage of petroleum products all over the country, transporters and retail customers from various parts of India have reported short supply of diesel and petrol over the past few days.

While diesel shortage has been attributed to diversion for industrial use and the inability of pump owners to ensure assured supplies, rationing of petrol due to panic buying has resulted in pumps running dry. In some cases, pump owners resort to hoarding to take advantage of price hike in the future, said sources aware of the developments.

“Members from various parts [of the country] are reporting short supply of diesel, which is hampering free movement of trucks. This is being caused by industrial customers buying in retail and pump owners restricting supply of diesel to trucks,” said Abhishek Gupta, General Secretary of the All India Transporters Welfare Association.

According to some transporters, there are pockets where fuel supply is restricted, but the situation has not gone out of hand.

“The primary reason is understood to be pump owners holding stocks in anticipation of price hikes



Tanking up: Diesel shortage is attributed to diversion for industrial use and that of petrol due to panic buying. SIDDHANT THAKUR

and industrial demand being fulfilled via retail where discount is available,” said a transporter.

There is a price difference of about ₹30 to ₹50 per litre between diesel meant for commercial/industrial use and retail fuel. Social media is flooded with videos of long queues at petrol pumps and supplies to retail customers restricted to just ₹100 or ₹200 worth of fuel in the case of two-wheelers and up to ₹2,000 for four-wheelers, after long hours of waiting. Several truckers are also seen complaining about either lack of fuel availability or supplies restricted to only ₹5,000 worth of fuel at a time.

This has slowed down truck movement, causing supply chain distributions, they said. Some petrol and diesel dealers pointed out

tense competition among oil marketing companies and they used to give credit of three to four days to dealers. This has been stopped since the first week of March, soon after the war broke out,” said Ravi Shinde, former president of the Petrol Dealers Association, Mumbai.

“This has created cash flow issues, and dealers, who used to order two tankers a day, are now getting one on upfront payment. The situation gets worse on Saturdays and Sundays when the banking channel does not work to process payment,” he said.

According to pump owners, when a pump goes dry due to unavailability of fuel, the pressure shifts to the nearby pump, leading to long queues and shortages of supply to retail customers.

Sometimes, rumours on social media of a likely steep hike in prices is also causing panic buying, said people familiar with the developments.

Owing to under recoveries, due to a loss of about ₹100 per litre of diesel, there is reluctance on the part of OMCs to sell more. They appear to be conserving inventories in the hope of better future pricing.

Now that international crude oil has touched \$113 a barrel, the alarm bell has started ringing. Meanwhile prices of essential groceries have gone up substantially, adding to the woes of households.

‘OMC losses down to ₹750 crore per day following fuel price hike’

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Following the ₹3 hike in the prices of petrol and diesel on May 16, the losses being incurred by oil marketing companies (OMCs) from liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), petrol and diesel combined have come down by ₹250 crore a day to ₹750 crore at present, said Joint Secretary at the Union Petroleum Ministry Sujata Sharma.

“Under-recovery is still there, and losses for the OMCs continue to occur. It is now estimated to be in the range of about ₹750 crore per day,” the senior official told reporters on Monday at the bi-weekly inter-ministerial briefing on the situation in West Asia. “That includes LPG, petrol and diesel combined,” she added.

Further, in response to a question from *The Hindu*, Ms. Sharma said no bailout package for OMCs is under consideration at present.

“Bailout package for OMCs is still not on the table,” she stated.

On May 10, Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri had said that the OMCs were making losses of about ₹1,000 crore per day, from buying crude, gas and LPG at higher prices and shielding consumers by selling the three retail fuels at lower prices. With the latest hike in the price of petrol and diesel, the losses have been trimmed by ₹250 crore per day.

‘Will buy Russian oil if it makes commercial sense’

Saptaparno Ghosh
Suhasini Haidar

Two days after U.S.’ second waiver on Russian oil purchases expired, the Centre emphasised India’s oil-marketing companies (OMCs) would continue purchasing crude from Moscow should they be commercially viable.

At the bi-weekly briefing on West Asia, Sujata Sharma, Joint-Secretary, Union Petroleum Ministry, said, “We have been purchasing

[crude oil] from Russia earlier - before the waiver, during the waiver and now also - it is basically [that] commercial sense, which should be there for OMCs to purchase.”

In the wake of the escalating tensions in West Asia, the U.S. had granted a month-long waiver on buying Russian and Iranian oil.

While the Iranian waiver lapsed April, the extended waiver on Russia expired May 16. With the latest waiver in place, In-



May-Elin Stener

dia’s import of Russian crude surged to 1.96 million barrels a day as of May 15 since the start of the month vis a vis 1.57 million

barrels a day in April, Kpler data show. This surge indicates Indian refiners rushing to secure stable supply.

Norway ready to supply Speaking to *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the Nordic Summit, Norwegian Ambassador May-Elin Stener stated amid the Russian situation, Oslo was ready to supply energy to India.

“Well, we will discuss these issues (expiry of U.S. waiver for Russian oil purchases) with India and of

course, we also have an understanding of the needs of the fastest growing big economy in the world,” she stated, adding, “What exactly would be the result, that I cannot say now.”

Norwegian government data show it exported 56.6 million barrels of oil in March or 27.3% higher than comparable period last year. It also exported 10.2 billion standard cubic metre of natural gas in the same period, although 0.3% lower year-on-year.

EU chief wants to seal pact on investment with India

Suhasini Haidar
T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
OSLO/NEW DELHI

President of the European Commission Ursula von der Leyen once again called for an investment pact between India and the European Union (EU), terming it a “missing piece of the puzzle” in bilateral cooperation plans.

Ms. von der Leyen was speaking at the European Business Round Table for Industry in Gothenburg, Sweden, where PM Narendra Modi also addressed.

The investment pact, being negotiated alongside the trade deal, was not finalised as the two sides could not agree on some key aspects, notable being dispute resolution.

‘Half the equation’ “But trade is only half the equation,” Ms. von der Leyen said. “Our next step must be to deliver an investment agreement. This is the missing piece of the puzzle in our reinforced economic cooperation, especially in a world where



Narendra Modi with Swedish PM Ulf Kristersson and Ursula von der Leyen in Gothenburg.

supply chains are being reshaped and economic security challenges us as never before. Deepening investment ties will help us to de-risk and diversify.”

During his address, Mr. Modi did not touch upon the investment agreement but instead highlighted the benefits of the trade deal and other pacts signed between the EU and India.

“The India-EU FTA will create new opportunities for industries, investors, and innovators,” he said.

“The India-EU Trade and Technology Council has further deepened our cooperation. We are work-

ing together in areas such as digital technology, clean energy, semiconductors, resilient supply chains, and innovation.”

‘Opened the door’

In the 26 years between January 2000 and December 2025, European countries have invested a little more than \$110 billion as direct investment in India, making up for about 14% of the total foreign direct investment India attracted during the period. However, the most recent years saw considerable volatility in the inflows from Europe.

For example, FDI from Europe stood at about \$5.5 billion in 2025, having fallen from about \$10.6 billion in 2024.

‘Holding back pact’

People tracking India-EU talks said the biggest factor holding up the investment agreement were the differences between the two economies on dispute resolution. Other issues were concerns over land acquisition, judicial protection and exit clauses.

FCI to raise ₹50,000 crore

The Food Corporation of India (FCI) will raise short-term debt of ₹50,000 crore from scheduled banks for a three-month tenure with a green shoe option to mop up an additional ₹25,000 crore. PTI

KANNUR
International Airport

KANNUR INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED
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For more details, please visit - www.etenders.kerala.gov.in.

E-Tender ID: 2026_KIAL_851153_1

Bid Submission Last Date: 5 June 2026, 1200 Hrs

TIRUMALA TIRUPATI DEVASTHANAMS - TIRUPATI
MARKETING DEPARTMENT e-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

e-Tenders are invited for supply of (1) 16,500 Kgs of Chilly powder (2) 90,000 Kgs of Cardamom (Elachi) 8 mm Size (CGEB) Variety through e-tenders to the Marketing Department, T.T.Devasthanams. For Tender notice and tender details log on to the web site <http://www.tirumala.org> and <https://tender.apeprocurement.gov.in>. For further details contact phone numbers: **0877-2264079, 2264555, FAX No: 0877-2264554.**

TTD-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.50) Date:18-05-2026

EXECUTIVE OFFICER

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001:2022 Certified Company)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The APTRANSCO invites bids online for Spec.No.PMM11-e-30/2026: Supply of 16 Nos Acoustic Imaging Cameras. Date & Time of availability of above tender: **18.05.2026 at 5:00PM.** Websites: www.tender.apeprocurement.gov.in and www.gem.gov.in. Contact No. CE/Transmission: 0866-2429230.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer/Transmission

R.O.No.GMCC/APTRANSCO/37/26-27

RAJASTHAN RAJYA VIDYUT PRASARAN NIGAM LIMITED

SHORT TERM N.I.T. No. 04/2026-27

BIDs are invited in prescribed format from Bidders registered in appropriate class RRVPNL / A or AA class in Central/ state Government Department and their undertakings in the O/o The Respective Executive Engineer (Civil) RVPN in NIB No.05 & 06/2026-27. All information regarding BIDs are available on <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, www.rvpn.co.in and <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>.

UBN :- VPN2627WSOB00395 to VPN2627WSOB00398 (4), VPN2627WSOB00403 (1), VPN2627WSOB00405 (1), VPN2627WSOB00419 to VPN2627WSOB00431 (13), VPN2627WSOB00435 to VPN2627WSOB00437 (3)

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer (Civil), Jaipur

Raj.Samwad/C/26/3011 R.R.V.P.N./TR-7570/2026

TVS VENU to buy a stake in Jana SFB

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

TVS VENU has agreed to acquire a minority stake in Jana Small Finance Bank Limited (Jana) through a combination of primary issuance of warrants and a secondary purchase for an equity ownership of up to 9.9% on a fully diluted basis, which includes 4.9% to be owned by TVS Motor

Company. TVS Venu has a long-standing presence in India’s financial services via TVS Credit Services. It has also signed pacts to buy 100% stake in PGIM India Asset Management.

Jana is present in mass retail and MSME banking. With over 12 million customers, it has advances and deposits of more than ₹35,000 crore each as of March 31, 2026.

Paramotor Digital files confidential IPO papers

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Paramotor Digital Technology Ltd. has filed confidential draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) under the pre-filing route toward a potential initial public offering (IPO).

GOVERNMENT OF KARNATAKA
DEPARTMENT OF SCHOOL EDUCATION
OFFICE OF THE COMMISSIONER, NEW PUBLIC OFFICES, NRUPATUNGA ROAD, BANGALORE-560 001, Mobile : 9448999424, E-mail : ddpiplanning@gmail.com, WEBSITE:(<http://www.schooleducation.kar.nic.in>)

No:DPI-CPI0PLN1/IVA-TENDER/2026-27 Date:18.05.2026

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION

Office of the Commissioner, Department of School Education, Bengaluru invites short term tender for identification of Independent Verification Agency for developing 500 to 800 KPS in coordination with Asian Development Bank.

1	RFP Reference No.	DPI/2026-27/SE0441/CALL-2
2	Date of Commencement of Download of RFP Document from Karnataka Public Procurement Portal website http://kppp.karnataka.gov.in	18/05/2026 onwards
3	Last Date and Time for uploading Online Queries in Karnataka Public Procurement Portal	20/05/2026 5:30 PM
4	Date and time of Pre-bid Meeting	20/05/2026 11:00 AM at the following venue: Office of Commissioner, School Education, First floor, New public office Building, Nrupatunga road, KR Circle, Bengaluru
5	Last Date and Time for uploading of RFP in Karnataka Public Procurement Portal	27/05/2026 5:00 PM
6	Date and Time of Online Opening of RFP Applications	29/05/2026 11:00 AM
7	Place of Opening of RFP Applications	Online at Karnataka Public Procurement Portal
8	Date and time of presentation for methodology on the project	01/06/2026 12:00 PM
9	Address for Communication	Office of the Commissioner, School Education, First floor, New public office Building, Nrupatunga Road, K R Circle, Bengaluru-560001, Email: ddpiplanning@gmail.com Contact: 080-22270072, 9448999424

Note: 1) Completed tenders shall be uploaded through e-tendering system by the Tenderers using their User ID on or before the last date & time stipulated. 2) In the event of the specified date of opening of RFP being declared a holiday for the employer, the RFP will be opened on the next working day at the same time. 3) Only Online Queries through Karnataka Public Procurement Portal will be accepted. Queries sent through letters, emails or any other mode will not be entertained.

Sd/-
DDPI(PLANNING)

DIPR/CPI/JA/719/2026-27

Greenlandic self-determination is non-negotiable, PM tells U.S. envoy



Cuba says it has right to defence as U.S. weighs alleged drone threat



Taiwan says it would 'welcome' its President speaking to Trump



Spain PM's party suffers record defeat in crucial Andalusia vote



Iran forms Hormuz Strait authority, demands coordination from vessels

Israeli forces intercept flotilla trying to reach blockaded Gaza

'Over 20 IS militants killed' in new strikes by Nigeria, U.S. forces

Russia launches attacks on Odesa and Dnipro as Ukraine targets Belgorod

Keir Starmer will not set out a timetable to quit: U.K. Deputy PM

Sport

Joy for Rai as he clinches first Major

World Championship matches are special and bring a lot of excitement, says Muzychuk

CM
Y
K

NO BIG DEAL

‘I don’t think Sooryavanshi has a weakness against slower ball’



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

After change of pace proved effective in dismissing Vaibhav Sooryavanshi on Sunday, RR batting coach Vikram Rathour dismissed suggestions that it might be a weakness. “Nobody is perfect; I don’t think slower ball is his weakness. On a pitch where the ball is gripping a bit, change of pace is good against anybody”.

SPACE FOR EVERYONE

T20 success does not depend on power-hitting alone: Rathour



RV. MOORTHY

Somebody like Virat Kohli is extremely successful, even in this format (T20). I won’t call him an out-and-out power-hitter. That tells you that there’s scope for everybody to succeed, provided you have belief in your abilities and can commit to whatever options you take while you are batting — Vikram Rathour, RR batting coach.

POOR STRATEGY

Bowling Ferreira in the 18th over was a bad move, says Gavaskar



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Handing the ball to Donovan Ferreira in the 18th over was a bad move. You are bringing a slow bowler on a pitch offering him no help. He was just bowling in the slot; it was his first over of the match. He had also scored a golden duck — Sunil Gavaskar criticises RR skipper Riyan Parag’s tactic against DC.

RARE FEAT

Rahul is fifth batter to score fifty or more 50 times in IPL history



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

K.L. Rahul became the fifth batter to score fifty or more 50 times in IPL history. Rahul joined Virat Kohli (76 — nine centuries and 67 half-centuries), David Warner (66 — four and 62), Shikhar Dhawan (53 — two and 51) and Rohit Sharma (51 — two and 49) during DC’s match against RR. Rahul has six tons and 44 half-centuries.

Cummins and Kishan show the way as Sunrisers secure spot in playoffs

Klaasen, too, plays a big role in the Hyderabad side’s win; the result also confirms Titans’ qualification while Super Kings’ hopes hang by a thread

IPL-19

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Sunrisers Hyderabad bowling coach Va-run Aaron had hailed Heinrich Klaasen as the fulcrum of the batting unit on the eve of his side’s clash against Chennai Super Kings.

On Monday, Klaasen justified that tag with a fine knock on a tricky surface to help his team beat Super Kings by five wickets in a vital IPL 2026 encounter at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium.

While Ishan Kishan head-lined the chase with a measured half-century (70, 47b, 7x4, 3x6), it was Klaasen’s 26-ball 47 (6x4, 2x6) that changed the course of the game.

SRH’s second win over CSK this season booked it a place in the playoffs. The result, which also put Gujarat Titans in the climactic phase, left Super Kings’ hopes hanging by a thread.

Chasing 181, Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma failed to get Sunrisers off to their usual flying start and they were in a spot of bother at 56 for two in the eighth over.

Klaasen, though, quickly went about tearing apart the Super Kings bowling attack with surgical precision.

Costly drop

Having been dropped on 18 by Spencer Johnson off Noor Ahmad, the South African piled on the agony,



The heroes: Kishan controlled the chase after Cummins’ three-for restricted Super Kings to 180 for seven. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

immediately smashing the Afghan spinner for a six and four; he also hit two more boundaries off Shivam Dube.

Klaasen’s knock allowed Kishan to grow in confidence at the other end. The left-hander took on

Anshul Kamboj in a 16-run 13th over. Once Klaasen departed, Kishan took charge and steered his side to within striking distance before being dismissed.

Earlier, cameos from Dewald Brevis (44, 27b, 2x4, 4x6) and Kartik Shar-



SCOREBOARD

CHENNAI SUPER KINGS

Sanju Samson c Kishan b Cummins 27 (13b, 5x4, 1x6), Ruturaj Gaikwad c Malinga b Cummins 15 (21b), Urvil Patel b Sakib 13 (8b, 2x6), Kartik Sharma c Nitish b Cummins 32 (19b, 3x4, 2x6), Dewald Brevis b Malinga 44 (27b, 2x4, 4x6), Shivam Dube b Sakib 26 (23b, 3x4, 1x6), Prashant Veer c & b Praful 11 (9b, 2x4), Akeal Hosein (not out) 3 (1b); Extras (nb-1, w-8): 9; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 180.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-31 (Samson, 2.3 overs), 2-48 (Urvil, 4.3), 3-90 (Kartik, 9.4), 4-100 (Ruturaj, 11.3), 5-159 (Brevis, 17.5), 6-164 (Dube, 18.3), 7-180 (Prashant, 19.6).

ma (32, 19b, 3x4, 2x6) helped Super Kings reach 180 for seven.

Sunrisers’ pacers, led by skipper Pat Cummins, were on the money in taking pace off their deliveries and bowling into the sur-face which was on the

SUNRISERS BOWLING

Nitish Kumar 2-0-35-0, Praful 3-0-37-1, Cummins 4-0-28-3, Malinga 4-0-26-1, Sakib 4-0-34-2, Shivang 3-0-20-0.

SUNRISERS HYDERABAD

Abhishek Sharma c Johnson b Akeal 26 (21b, 3x4, 1x6), Travis Head (Impact Player for Sakib) c & b Mukesh 6 (6b, 1x4), Ishan Kishan c Urvil b Kamboj 70 (47b, 7x4, 3x6), Heinrich Klaasen st. Samson b Noor 47 (26b, 6x4, 2x6), Nitish Kumar c Urvil b Mukesh 11 (7b, 1x4), Salil Arora (not out) 10 (5b, 1x6), R. Smaran (not out) 5 (2b, 1x4); Extras (w-6): 6; Total (for five wkts. in 19 overs): 181.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-18 (Head, 2.3), 2-56 (Abhishek,

7.4), 3-131 (Klaasen, 14.3), 4-153 (Nitish, 17.1), 5-175 (Kishan, 18.3).

SUPER KINGS BOWLING

Mukesh (Impact Player for Kartik) 4-0-36-2, Johnson 3-0-26-0, Kamboj 4-0-46-1, Noor 4-0-40-1, Akeal 3-0-21-1, Dube 1-0-12-0.

Toss: CSK; PoM: Kishan. SRH won by five wickets with six balls to spare.

Next assignment

CSK: May 21 vs. GT Ahmedabad, 7.30 p.m.

SRH: May 22 vs. RCB Hyderabad, 7.30 p.m.

vis helped the hosts finish with a respectable total.

However, it wasn’t enough once a determined Kishan and Klaasen took strike as Ruturaj Gaikwad’s men ended their final home game of the season on a sour note.

Starc is one of the best role models: Badani

Anirudh Velamuri
NEW DELHI

For a long period on Sunday, Rajasthan Royals seemed destined to bury Delhi Capitals under a massive first-innings score. But veteran left-arm pacer Mitchell Starc flipped the script.

The visitor was cruising at 161 for two before Starc produced a devastating burst in the death overs — scalping four wickets — and derailed the innings. The spell ultimately proved decisive in Capitals’ five-wicket win. His performance earned glowing praise from DC head coach Hemang Badani, who termed the 36-year-old “one of the best role models in the sport.”

“His work ethic, preparation with his own plans and training are above par. I don’t even see that with a lot of the younger boys. That’s the reason he has sustained for so long. He’s



Starc... impact player. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

always talking to the younger lads and trying to pass on the knowledge. There is immense conversation that Starc brings to the table,” Badani said.

Badani also lamented Starc’s absence for a significant portion of the season while expressing hope that a long-term solution could eventually be worked out between franchises and National boards.

Win toss and field first — the dominant trend

Natalia Hannah Rice

Flip the coin, call it right, point to the field. It has become as predictable as batting fireworks in a PowerPlay. Season after season, captains have surrendered to the same instinct, and IPL 2026 has offered no deviation from that well-worn path.

In the 63 matches this season (till the Chennai Super Kings-Sunrisers Hyderabad clash on Monday), toss winners have elected to field in 52.

The logic is old: dew in evening games makes it difficult to grip the ball, blunts spin, and tilts the contest decisively in favour of the side batting second. It is a formula that has been applied across editions, and in 2026, nobody has seen fit to discard it.

Teams that chose to field went on to win thirty two of those 52. In the first 48 matches, sides chasing



Ruturaj and Cummins at the toss. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

200 or more held a 12-11 win-loss record, against 4-13 at the same stage last year. IPL 2026 has already produced 38 successful chases in 58 games.

Batting first, meanwhile, has been a lonely road. Only 11 toss winners have gone against the grain

and chosen to take first strike, and just one of them has emerged triumphant — Rajasthan Royals against Gujarat Titans on April 4. The other 10 went on to lose, a grim ledger that has kept captains firmly wedded to the field-first faith.

Some big moments of the season have only deepened that conviction. Mumbai Indians, sent in to experience the pitch first at Wankhede, made 243 for five — its highest-ever first-innings IPL total — only for Sunrisers Hyderabad to swallow it with eight balls to spare.

Punjab Kings hunted down 265 against Delhi Capitals, the highest successful chase in T20 history. K.L. Rahul’s unbeaten 152 off just 67 balls, the highest IPL score by an Indian, was still not enough. His side had batted first.

Decision-making after the toss has become less a gamble and more a script.

P.K. Ajith Kumar
JAIPUR

Mayank Yadav is that rare Indian talent. The genuine fast bowler. He had made a dream debut in the IPL two years ago, when he took three for 27 for Lucknow Super Giants against Punjab Kings and clocked 155.8 kmph - the fastest ball yet of the season. He went on to bowl even quicker.

But life has not been kind to Mayank after that

brilliant start to his career. He got injured and the comeback hasn’t been easy.

His bowling coach at LSG, Bharat Arun, however, has still plenty of faith in him. “Mayank is such a rare talent for us, but unfortunately, he has been out due to injuries for the last two years and has been inconsistent while playing. He is now fit and raring to go and bowling with good pace. He is somebody we have to take care of”.

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Royal Challengers (Q)	13	9	4	0	18	1.065
Gujarat Titans (Q)	13	8	5	0	16	0.400
Sunrisers Hyderabad (Q)	13	8	5	0	16	0.350
Punjab Kings	13	6	6	1	13	0.227
Rajasthan Royals	12	6	6	0	12	0.027
Chennai Super Kings	13	6	7	0	12	-0.016
Delhi Capitals	13	6	7	0	12	-0.871
Kolkata Knight Riders	12	5	6	1	11	-0.038
Mumbai Indians (E)	12	4	8	0	8	-0.504
Lucknow Super Giants (E)	12	4	8	0	8	-0.701

Q: Qualified | E: Eliminated

Modric picked in Croatia’s WC squad

Associated Press
ZAGREB

Luka Modric was on Monday included in Croatia’s squad as the 40-year-old midfielder is set to play in his fifth World Cup.

Croatia coach Zlatko Dalic named a 26-man roster also featuring Ivan Perisic, who scored in the past three tournaments. Modric broke his cheekbone last month but the Croatia captain is expected to be fit when Croatia kicks off its World Cup campaign against England on June 17.

The squad: Goalkeepers:

Dominik Livakovic, Dominik Kotarski, Ivor Pandur;

Defenders: Josko Gvardiol, Duje Caleta-Car, Josip Sutalo, Josip Stolic, Martin Pogracic, Martin Erlic, Luka Vuskovic; Midfielders: Luka Modric, Mateo Kovacic, Mario Pasalic, Nikola Vlasic, Luka Jusic, Martin Baturina, Kristijan Jakic, Petar Susic, Nikola Moro, Toni Fruk; Forwards: Ivan Perisic, Andrej Kramaric, Ante Budimir, Marco Pasalic, Petar Musa, Igor Matanovic.

Tarun Shastry

In the high-octane world of the Indian Premier League, momentum is a fragile currency. Franchises spend a fortune trying to manufacture it, yet it can disappear in an instant.

For much of the first half of the 2026 season, Gujarat Titans looked like a side rich in talent but lacking in balance. Its top-heavy batting line-up often left the middle-order vulnerable, while a star-studded bowling attack struggled to find the control needed to suffocate opponents through the middle overs.

Then came the turning point: Jason Holder.

At 6-foot-7, the Barbadian did not simply enter the playing XI - he transformed it. GT now sits second in the points table, winning five of its last six matches, with 16 points.

Holder has been far more than a tactical adjustment; he has emerged as the catalyst behind the side's resurgence, offering a masterclass in how a genuine three-dimensional cricketer can instantly reshape a franchise's fortunes.

When GT outbid Chennai Super Kings to sign Holder for ₹7 crore at the auction, the move was viewed as a smart depth acquisition. His absence from the opening matches raised questions, but his eventual inclusion has completely rebalanced Shubman Gill's side.

Impactful

The numbers underline just how impactful he has been. Across six matches, Holder has claimed 13 wickets at a staggering average of 10.92, while maintaining an economy rate of 6.35 and a strike rate of 10.30.

Among bowlers who have delivered at least 15 overs this season, Holder boasts both the best bowling average and strike rate in the tournament. His lower-order contributions with the bat have only added to GT's tactical flexibility.

Holder announced himself immediately in a high-pressure away fixture against Royal Challengers Bengaluru at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium. He smashed a rapid 23 off just 10 balls, including two towering sixes, to provide late momentum before returning figures of 3.5-0-35-1 to help GT secure victory.

He followed that with a disciplined outing at Chepauk against CSK. On a surface demanding precision, Holder delivered four controlled overs for just 22 runs, applying pressure that allowed Kagiso Rabada to attack aggressively from the other end.

Against RCB in Ahmedabad, Holder used his height brilliantly to extract steep bounce from the Narendra Modi Stadium surface, finishing with figures of 4-0-29-2 while also contributing a valuable 12 off 10 balls during a tense chase.

The 34-year-old's defining performance, however, came against Punjab Kings in Ahmedabad. Holder tore through the batting

Before Holder's arrival, Titans relied heavily on Gill, Sai Sudharsan, and Buttler to either set or chase totals. The West Indian's presence fundamentally changed that dynamic

lineup with a devastating spell of seam bowling, finishing with 4-0-24-4, his best returns in IPL and deservedly earning the Player of the Match award.

He then showcased his adaptability on a slower Jaipur surface against Rajasthan Royals, dismantling the middle order with clever cutters and defensive lengths to claim three wickets in a devastating 2.3-over burst. Most recently, against the explosive Sunrisers Hyderabad batting lineup, Holder once again delivered under pressure. He scalped three wickets and remained unbeaten on 11 off 10 balls to guide GT home comfortably.

Before his arrival, Titans relied heavily on Shubman Gill, Sai Sudharsan, and Jos Buttler to either set or chase totals. Holder's presence has fundamentally changed that dynamic, forming a reliable lower-order partnership with Rahul Tewatia and giving the Titans a level of insurance they previously lacked.

Importantly, Holder's IPL resurgence is no isolated purple patch. It is a continuation of the elite form he displayed on the international stage during the recent T20 World Cup, where he was central to West Indies' campaign.

During that period, he became the first West Indian bowler to reach 100 T20 International wickets. He

The Titan maker

Control with the ball, crucial lower-order runs, and composure under pressure - Holder has changed the rhythm of Gujarat's season. Now, Gill's men look one of the most complete teams in the tournament and are gathering momentum going into the playoffs



finished the tournament with 10 wickets at an exceptional average of 12.20 and an economy rate of 6.65, excelling both with the new ball and at the death through his variations and hard lengths.

His batting contributions proved equally valuable. Against South Africa, Holder produced a counterattacking 49 that single-handedly kept West Indies in the contest. He followed it with an unbeaten 37 against India in Kolkata, striking at 168.18 while anchoring a crucial 76-run partnership.

It was this ability to influence games across multiple phases that convinced Titans to go all-in for him at the auction.

Elite-level experience

Holder's impact is rooted in more than a decade of elite-level experience. Since making his IPL debut in 2013, he has shown how good a utility player he is. His journey began with

Chennai Super Kings, where he played six matches as a raw 21-year-old. Stints with Sunrisers Hyderabad and Kolkata Knight Riders followed, but it was during his second spell with SRH that he evolved into a genuine T20 force.

In 2020, Holder claimed 14 wickets in just seven matches, and he followed it up in 2021 with 16 wickets in eight games alongside valuable lower-order runs. Lucknow Super Giants then signed him for the 2022 season, where he collected 14 wickets in 12 matches before moving to Rajasthan Royals in 2023.

Awkward release point

What makes Holder such a formidable force in modern T20 cricket is the combination of physical advantage, tactical evolution, and composure under pressure. With his tall physique, he generates an awkward release point that few batters can comfortably handle.

On abrasive subcontinental surfaces, Holder does not rely on raw pace; instead, he relentlessly attacks hard lengths, extracting steep and often unpredictable bounce that forces mistakes.

Equally important has been the evolution of his white-ball skillset. During a prolific stretch across franchise cricket, Holder broke the record for the most T20 wickets in a calendar year with 97 scalps. That relentless workload refined his slower balls, wide yorkers, and off-cutters into elite death-bowling weapons.

Blessed with calmness forged through years of captaining West Indies during

Holder's impact is rooted in more than a decade of elite-level experience. Since making his IPL debut in 2013, he has shown how good a utility player he is

turbulent periods, Holder has become a stabilising influence in GT's attack. While Rabada, Mohammed Siraj, and Prasidh Krishna hunt wickets aggressively, Holder provides the control and clarity that allows plans to function cohesively.

As IPL 2026 approaches its business end, Titans are no longer merely contenders - they are genuine title favourites. That transformation can largely be traced back to Holder's inclusion.

He has solved the side's structural weaknesses, strengthened the lower order, and elevated the bowling unit into one of the most complete attacks in the tournament.

Lending competitive edge

Momentum in the IPL can disappear overnight. But since Holder walked into Titans' XI, it has only gathered force. He has given the side control, composure, and a ruthless competitive edge at exactly the right stage of the season.

Now, with the playoffs looming, the Titans are no longer just chasing the trophy, they look built to seize it. And standing at the centre of that charge is a towering all-rounder who has turned the side's campaign on its head.

THE GIST

▼

Holder has been far more than a tactical adjustment; he has emerged as the catalyst behind the side's resurgence, offering a masterclass in how a genuine three-dimensional cricketer can instantly reshape a franchise's fortunes

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Blessed with calmness forged through years of captaining West Indies during turbulent periods, he has become a stabilising influence in GT's attack

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What makes Holder such a formidable force in modern T20 cricket is the combination of physical advantage, tactical evolution, and composure under pressure. With his tall physique, he generates an awkward release point that few batters can comfortably handle

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount approved for development projects in Maharashtra

993.72 crore. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday said that the government approved development projects for six pilgrimage and heritage sites, including Bhimashankar Temple, Grishneshwar Temple, Ajinkyatara Fort. PTI

People abducted during attacks on schools in Nigeria

46 At least 46 people were kidnapped during attacks on three schools in southwest Nigeria's Oyo state last week, according to the Christian Association of Nigeria. Gunmen targeted multiple schools simultaneously, prompting authorities to temporarily shut nearby institutions. AFP

Age of the youngest Indian-origin Mayor elected in the U.K.

23 23-year-old Tushar Kumar has become the youngest Indian-origin Mayor in the U.K. after taking charge as Mayor of Elstree and Borehamwood in eastern England. He said he hopes to focus on youth participation, community engagement and local public service during his term. PTI

Growth recorded in China's solar cell exports in April

60 in per cent. 60% growth was recorded in China's solar cell exports in April compared to a year earlier, data showed. China shipped solar products worth \$3.12 billion, as strong demand from Southeast Asia and Africa continued despite exports easing from March's record highs. REUTERS

Body-worn cameras deployed by J&K traffic police

685 685 body-worn cameras have been deployed by the Jammu and Kashmir Traffic Police along with more than 350 modern enforcement vehicles to strengthen traffic monitoring and road safety across the Union Territory. PTI
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The warning signs in India's import bill

PM's appeal to reduce spending on petroleum products, edible oils, gold and foreign travel shows concern over India's import dependence; with foreign currency outgo increasing due to higher imports of crude oil, fertilizers, electronic components, pressure is mounting on foreign exchange reserves and the rupee

ECONOMIC NOTES

Biswajit Dhar

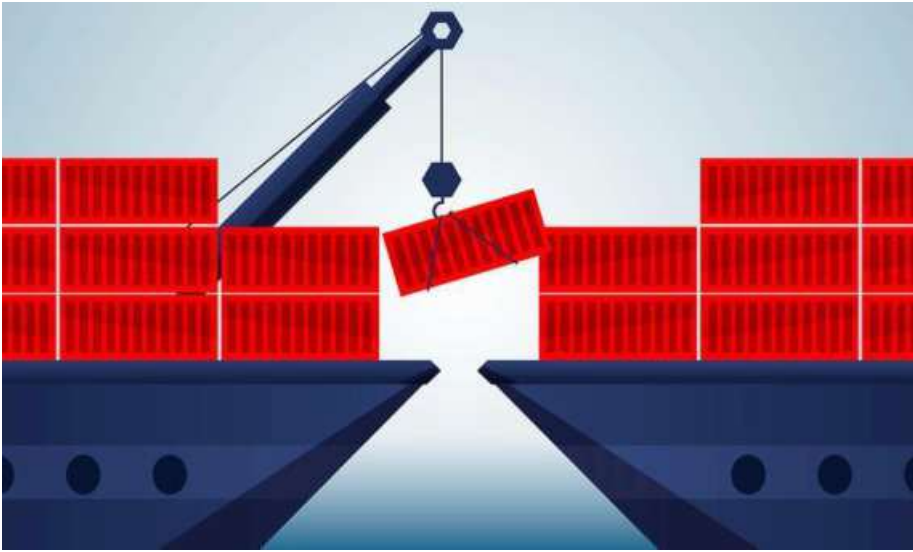
Last week, Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged citizens to reduce spending on petroleum products, cut edible oil consumption, delay non-essential gold purchases by a year, avoid unnecessary foreign travel, and prioritise the purchase of locally made products. He also advised increased use of public transport and electric vehicles, and called for the revival of Covid-era measures such as work-from-home, all aimed at reducing petrol and diesel consumption.

Mr. Modi's appeals have a singular focus – reducing the country's foreign currency spending. This is an alarm bell that no government has sounded before, not even during the severe economic crisis of 1991, when the country's foreign exchange reserves were less than \$1 billion, barely enough to finance imports for a fortnight. The Reserve Bank of India was then forced to pledge the country's gold to the Bank of England, the Bank of Japan, and later to the Union Bank of Switzerland to avoid defaulting on international debt obligations.

A widening trade deficit

The Prime Minister's announcement seems to be in response to the delicate situation India is facing in its merchandise trade account. In 2025-26, India's merchandise trade deficit reached a record \$333 billion, an increase of over 17% as compared to the immediately preceding year. The bulge in trade deficit was caused by imports rising 7% to an all-time high of \$775 billion, while exports remained nearly stagnant at \$442 billion.

Higher crude oil prices in the international market following the U.S.-Israel war against Iran are yet to be reflected in the import figures. According to the International Monetary Fund's (IMF) crude oil price index, prices have risen by 53% since the war began. When these numbers are reflected in India's



GETTY IMAGES

import bill, the situation could be really worrying. This could be the reason for the Prime Minister to press the alarm bell.

India's imports in 2025-26 were driven by four product groups – gold and silver, edible oils, fertilizers, and electronic components. Imports of precious metals, valued at over \$90 billion, accounted for about 12% of the import bill, marking them the third largest product group in the import basket after crude oil and electronics. Overall imports of gems and jewellery increased by almost 25% over the previous year, with most of the increase driven by gold imports, which rose by 24%, and silver imports, which surged by 150%. Exports of gems and jewellery, on the other hand, declined by over 5%, indicating that the increased imports of the precious metals were mostly absorbed domestically.

Import dependence

The unprecedented rise in gold imports has continued into the new financial year, increasing by 82% in April 2026 compared to the year before. This raises the question of whether the Prime Minister's appeal to postpone non-essential gold purchases, along with last week's increase in customs duty on gold and silver

imports to 15%, will be enough to arrest this upward trend.

The probability of lower gold imports may seem low, as continued stock market volatility has pushed retail investors into diversifying their portfolios by opting for both physical and gold ETFs. In fact, there are expectations that a higher import duty on physical gold will increase the shift towards ETF gold.

India's dependence on the international market for edible oils has been the most disappointing aspect of the country's agricultural performance. Edible oil imports increased by over 12% in 2025-26 and accelerated to 40% in April 2026 (over April 2025). These numbers are a pointer that import dependence on this critical commodity may have worsened. Imports accounted for over 56% of India's edible oil demand in 2023-24, the most recent year for which official data are available. Since the government has failed to find a way to increase domestic oilseed production, it needs citizens to reduce edible oil consumption to reduce imports, and thus save foreign currency.

Imports have brought bad news for agriculture. Spiralling fertilizer prices in international markets are not only causing

the country to lose foreign currency due to its high import dependence, but they are also likely to raise the fertilizer subsidy bill. Globally, fertilizer prices increased by 46% between December 2025 and April 2026, while urea prices doubled during this period.

Over the past five years, fertilizer imports have met between 31% and 37% of India's requirements. However, this share is expected to exceed 50% in 2025-26 as urea imports increased by over 60%. Disruptions caused by the war in West Asia have pushed India's fertilizer import bill up by nearly 80% in 2025-26. As in the case of edible oil, it remains a mystery why domestic production was not ramped up to reduce foreign exchange outgo.

Pressure on the rupee

Though Mr. Modi has urged citizens to "prioritise Made in India products," the Atmanirbhar Bharat Abhiyan, launched in 2020 to reduce dependence on Chinese imports, has not made much headway in several key industries. Even after six years and huge budgetary outlays under the PLI scheme, India remains significantly dependent on imports of electronic components, which grew by over 20% in the previous fiscal year.

Domestic production of accumulators and batteries was also to be stepped up to reduce the import content of electric vehicles, but in 2025-26, imports of these products increased by 50%. India's transition towards greater technological sophistication is thus coming at the cost of considerable foreign currency outgo.

Finally, a rising trade deficit could create another significant irritant as the already weakened rupee could slide further. Over the past several months, the RBI has been selectively intervening to prevent a free-fall of the currency. However, RBI needs to carefully calibrate its market interventions since foreign currency reserves have fallen by over \$21 billion since the end of February 2026, and a further decline may not be prudent. (Biswajit Dhar is former professor, Jawaharlal Nehru University)

THE GIST

India's record merchandise trade deficit and rising import dependence have increased concerns over foreign currency outgo and pressure on the rupee.

Increases in imports of gold, edible oils, fertilizers and electronic components have exposed the country's continued dependence on international markets.

Why has the WHO declared a PHEIC over Ebola outbreak?

What is Ebola? How is Ebola transmitted? What measures are being taken to contain the outbreak?

Ramya Kannan

The story so far :

On May 16, the World Health Organization (WHO) declared the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) and Uganda a 'public health emergency of international concern' (PHEIC). Just ahead of that, the Ministry of Public Health, Hygiene and Social Welfare, DRC, and the Uganda Ministry of Health declared an Ebola outbreak.

What is a PHEIC?

A PHEIC is the WHO's highest level of global health alert, formally declared under the International Health Regulations, whenever the health event is 'serious, sudden, unexpected, or unusual, and poses a public health risk to other countries through spread'. The declaration of the PHEIC also calls for a coordinated global response to tackle the current outbreak.

A new Ebola outbreak was notified in eastern DRC and Uganda, reportedly driven by the Bundibugyo ebolavirus strain. According to the WHO report, as of May 16, eight laboratory-confirmed cases, 246 suspected cases, and 80 suspected deaths have been reported in Ituri Province of the DRC. In addition, two laboratory-confirmed cases (including one death) with no apparent link to each other have been reported in Kampala, Uganda, within 24 hours of each other, among two individuals travelling from the DRC.

What is Ebola?

Ebola virus disease is a zoonotic disease that can be severe and often fatal in humans. It is caused by the eponymic Ebola virus, and has spilled over to humans from wild animals, including fruit bats and non-human primates, but is now capable of spreading between humans whenever there is direct contact with blood, secretion, bodily fluids of those

infected, and even contaminated surfaces. According to the WHO, three different viruses are known to cause large Ebola disease outbreaks: Ebola virus, Sudan virus, and Bundibugyo virus. This current epidemic involves the last variant.

Ebola has been known since 1976, with most early outbreaks occurring in remote villages of Central Africa. However, things changed dramatically with the worst Ebola outbreak in history, which occurred in West Africa from 2014 to 2016, sweeping across Guinea, Liberia, and Sierra Leone, resulting in over 28,600 reported cases and 11,325 deaths.

But this outbreak served as a milestone turning point for the way in which the world treated Ebola; it catalysed unprecedented global support for research and development into vaccines for Ebola. As a result, there are two vaccines in the market that have been approved for Ebola, in a single and double dose regimen. Both are being used for targeted "ring vaccination" for all

contacts and frontline workers dealing with the cases, as post-exposure prophylaxis. There are monoclonal-antibody treatments in the market that reportedly improve survival when given early to patients.

What measures are in place now?

The WHO-led response now focuses on several aspects including rapid isolation of a patient and immediate provision of intensive supportive care (rehydration, symptom management) to reduce mortality. But what will be crucial in actually containing this outbreak is to initiate rapid case tracing, contact tracing, ensuring safe burials, and establishing strict infection-control measures in all health facilities where people are being treated. The WHO's plan also includes deploying approved vaccines and monoclonal antibodies to at-risk groups wherever feasible. An essential part of the strategy, according to the global agency, is to launch social mobilisation campaigns to build trust, reduce stigma, and encourage early care-seeking among the people in the affected zones.

According to the WHO, "outbreak control relies on a package of interventions including intensive supportive care of patients, infection prevention and control, disease surveillance and contact tracing, laboratory services, safe and dignified burials, vaccination if relevant, and social mobilisation."

THE GIST

WHO declared the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Uganda a public health emergency of international concern (PHEIC), its highest level of global health alert.

The outbreak, driven by the Bundibugyo ebolavirus strain, has prompted rapid isolation, contact tracing, safe burials, vaccination, and monoclonal-antibody treatment.

